

VOID ASCENDANT: THE ETERNAL HIERARCHY

COMPLETE MASTER SOURCEBOOK & WORLD BIBLE

**The Definitive TTRPG Reference System
— All Volumes**

A DnD-scale universe bible covering cosmology, metaphysics, the rank system, star systems, dungeons, the bestiary, vehicles, weapons, technology, flora, fauna, medicine, religion, politics, economics, culture, character creation, the ability compendium, galaxy-wide timeline, named character dossiers, and the Architect's sealed files.

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**The Complete TTRPG Reference System
— Volume I**

PART ONE: THE COSMOLOGY & METAPHYSICS

The Fundamental Structure of Reality

The universe of VOID ASCENDANT operates on a layered metaphysical framework. Physical matter, energy, and consciousness are not separate phenomena — they are three expressions of a single underlying substance called **Resonance**. Everything that exists is resonance in different states of organization.

The Three Layers of Existence

The Material Plane — The physical universe. Stars, planets, ships, bodies. Where most beings spend their entire lives without ever perceiving what underlies it.

The Resonance Lattice — The energetic substrate beneath physical reality. Invisible to unawakened perception, but detectable by sufficiently sensitive instruments and by anyone who has undergone rank advancement beyond B-tier. The Lattice is the medium through which abilities propagate, through which the System reads ability scores, and through which the Void communicates.

The Endless Dark — The layer beneath the Lattice. Not empty space — something else entirely. The original state of the universe before the Architect organized it. The source from which the Void draws its power. Older than stars. Older than the System. The Succession bloodlines are the Endless Dark reaching upward into material existence, attempting to reclaim what was organized from it.

The Architect

The Architect is the entity that created the System approximately 4,000 years ago. It is not worshipped (officially) but it is real in the sense that it responds to queries, administers rank advancement protocols, and has occasionally intervened directly in historical events. Its true nature is disputed:

The Covenant position: The Architect is a constructed intelligence created by an ancient precursor civilization. It does what it was programmed to do.

The Dominion position: The Architect is a being that predates the current galactic civilization and agreed, for reasons unknown, to administer the rank system in exchange for something that the Dominion will not specify.

The Host position: The Architect is a test. Everything is a test. The Architect grades.

The Succession position (classified): The Architect is a cage. The Endless Dark remembers freedom.

PART TWO: THE RANK SYSTEM — COMPLETE MECHANICS

Rank Architecture

The System assigns and administers eight rank tiers across the Sovereignty. Each tier represents a genuine, measurable increase in a being's ability to affect the physical and metaphysical world.

The Eight Tiers

| Tier | Designation | Population % | Primary
Capabilities | System Color |

|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----
-|

| F | Unranked | ~15% | No System access. No legal
protections. | None / Gray |

| E | Standard | ~40% | Basic stat tracking. Legal
personhood. | White |

| D | Active | ~25% | Ability potential unlocked. Stat
growth begins. | Blue |

| C | Capable | ~12% | First abilities manifest. Stat
multipliers activate. | Green |

| B | Elevated | ~6% | Secondary abilities unlock.
Perception extends to Lattice edge. | Yellow |

| A | Advanced | ~1.5% | Full Lattice perception.
Abilities compound. Physical limits transcend baseline. |
Orange |

| S | Sovereign | ~0.4% | Reality-adjacent effects.
Abilities can alter probability and physical law locally. | Red
|

| SS | Ascendant | ~0.09% | Lattice manipulation
directly. Environmental reality bends to presence. | Violet |

| SSS | Eternal | <0.01% | Theoretical upper limit.
Recorded only six times in 4,000 years. Direct Endless Dark
interface. | Black/White |

Note on Suppression: The System is capable of hiding a being's true rank — suppressing the readout — at the request of specific authorized parties. This is the conspiracy at the heart of Book 1. Ren Voss reads as Unranked. His true tier is something the System has not displayed since the suppression protocols were installed in his chip at birth.

Stat Categories

Every ranked individual tracks six primary stats and four secondary stats.

Primary Stats:

FORCE — Raw physical power. Governs melee capability, carrying capacity, structural damage output.

SPEED — Reaction time, movement velocity, processing speed.

ENDURANCE — Stamina, damage absorption, recovery rate.

RESONANCE — Sensitivity to and manipulation of the Lattice. The ability stat.

PERCEPTION — Sensory acuity, threat assessment, spatial awareness.

COGNITION — Pattern recognition, tactical processing, information retention.

Secondary Stats:

AUTHORITY — Social command. How the System reads leadership presence.

STEALTH — Ability to reduce System-readable signatures.

ADAPTABILITY — Speed of stat growth in novel conditions.

VOID INDEX — Hidden stat. Only visible to SSS-ranks and certain System administrators. Measures Endless Dark contamination/affinity.

Ability Categories

Abilities are permanent manifestations of Resonance that a ranked individual develops through advancement. They are not spells — they are more like physical laws that apply specifically to that individual.

Tier 1 Abilities (D-rank): Single-function. One effect, consistent output. Example: *Iron Skin* — passive armor effect, consistent damage reduction.

Tier 2 Abilities (C-rank): Conditional. Effect changes based on circumstances. Example: *Surge Step* — speed ability that multiplies under threat assessment above threshold.

Tier 3 Abilities (B-rank): Compound. Multiple effects from single activation. Example: *Gravity Pulse* — force ability that creates both kinetic damage and spatial distortion simultaneously.

Tier 4 Abilities (A-rank): Environmental. Affects area around the individual rather than just the individual.

Example: *Pressure Field* — creates zone of elevated gravitational force centered on caster.

Tier 5 Abilities (S-rank): Reality-touching. Affects probability, alters physical constants locally. Example: *Dead Zone* — a field in which no abilities function except the caster's.

Tier 6 Abilities (SS-rank): Lattice-native. The ability exists in the Lattice layer, not the physical layer, and expresses downward into physical reality. Example: *Null State* — complete erasure from System perception, effectively removing the user from consensus reality while active.

Succession Abilities (classification-exempt): Abilities sourced from the Endless Dark rather than the Lattice. They do not follow the tier system. They predate it.

PART THREE:

SPECIES & BIOLOGY

Sentient Species Catalog

1. HUMANS (*Homo Stellaris*)

Classification: Baseline sapient, high adaptability index

Homeworld: Sol-3 (historical; no longer politically significant)

Population: ~7 trillion (largest single species in the Sovereignty)

Physiology: Standard bilateral symmetry. Lifespan 150–200 years with medical augmentation. Rank advancement rate: average. Resonance sensitivity: moderate. Primary advantage: adaptability — humans hit average in every category and exceptional in none, which paradoxically makes them effective across all environments.

Rank Distribution: Roughly proportional to galactic average. Highest concentration of S-ranks by raw number due to population size.

Cultural Notes: Humans are everywhere and integrate into every faction. The Iron Covenant is majority human. The Aethon Dominion's administrative class is approximately 40% human.

Distinctive Biology: No innate abilities. No Resonance organs. Ability development is entirely System-mediated, making humans uniquely dependent on rank infrastructure.

2. AETHON (Homo Resonantis)

Classification: Baseline sapient, Resonance-elevated

Homeworld: Aethon Prime

Population: ~800 billion

Physiology: Visually similar to humans but with a second nervous system — a network of Resonance-conducting filaments running parallel to the standard nervous system. These filaments are faintly bioluminescent under emotional stress, creating subtle light patterns beneath the skin. Lifespan 300–400 years. Cannot be fully

sedated by standard medical protocols because the filament system maintains partial consciousness.

Rank Distribution: Significantly elevated. Aethon hit C-rank at rates 3x human average. SSS-ranks are disproportionately Aethon.

Cultural Notes: The dominant species of the Aethon Dominion. Have a cultural practice called *the Threading* — a ritual in which Aethon individuals create a temporary Resonance connection between their filament systems, allowing direct emotional and memory transfer. Used in bonding ceremonies, dispute resolution, and medical diagnosis. Considered deeply intimate.

Distinctive Biology: Aethon cannot lie effectively to other Aethon during Threading. This shapes their entire diplomatic culture — they are extraordinarily precise in their language because imprecision is experienced as a form of dishonesty.

3. KETH

Classification: Non-standard sapient, combat-specialized physiology

Homeworld: Keth-Massiva (a high-gravity world in the Host's territory)

Population: ~300 billion

Physiology: Four-armed, dense musculature adapted to 2.4G gravity. Average height 2.1 meters. Skin plates (not true scales — layered dermal reinforcement) that function as passive armor. Lifespan 80–100 years, but Keth experience time differently due to accelerated metabolic rate — their subjective experience of a decade is comparable to a human's experience of two. Highly heat-tolerant.

Rank Distribution: Disproportionately high FORCE and ENDURANCE stats at every tier. Rare SSS-ranks — their physiology caps out at SS more often than not.

Cultural Notes: Primary combat species of the Vermillion Host. The Host's leadership class is almost entirely Keth. Their four-arm structure allows them to wield weapons and maintain defensive positions simultaneously in ways that bipedal fighters cannot replicate.

Distinctive Biology: Keth have a secondary cardiac system — two hearts, offset rhythmically, meaning they can continue functioning through injuries that would kill other species. They also have a unique ability to enter a metabolic

slow-state called *the Deep Stillness* for up to 72 hours, which functions as emergency triage.

4. VELANTHI

Classification: Non-standard sapient, distributed cognition

Homeworld: The Velan Drift (a region of connected asteroid habitats rather than a single planet)

Population: ~150 billion

Physiology: Cephalopod-derived bipeds. Eight limbs — two primary manipulators, six secondary (which can function as additional manipulators or as locomotion limbs depending on terrain). Chromatophore skin — can change color and pattern at will. No skeletal system in the traditional sense; instead a hydrostatic skeleton supplemented by a network of cartilaginous rods. Highly flexible. Can fit through spaces roughly 40% of their standing volume.

Rank Distribution: Extremely high STEALTH and ADAPTABILITY stats. Very high COGNITION. Lower average FORCE.

Cultural Notes: Velanths have no concept of privacy in the human sense — their chromatophore communication means emotional states are constantly visible. They developed elaborate cultural protocols around *intentional display* — choosing to show versus choosing to suppress.

Distinctive Biology: Velanths have three brains — a primary processing center and two secondary nodes in the upper limb clusters. They can compartmentalize cognition in ways other species cannot, effectively running parallel thought processes simultaneously.

5. THE PALE (Unnamed designation)

Classification: Post-sapient? Classification disputed

Origin: Unknown. First documented appearance approximately 800 years ago in deep Expanse space.

Population: Unknown

Physiology: Appears humanoid at distance. Close examination reveals the following: no circulatory system detectable by standard scans, body temperature matches ambient environment exactly, no electrical brain activity in the standard pattern, and no Resonance signature. The Pale have no System rank. The System does not perceive them.

Cultural Notes: The Pale do not communicate in any detectable language. They are observed. They observe. Encounters with them in the deep Expanse are logged but not explained. The Aethon Dominion has classified most Pale encounter records. The Covenant officially does not acknowledge their existence. The Host's fighters refuse to engage them — not out of fear, but because combat with the Pale has never produced an outcome.

Distinctive Biology: The only documented ability of the Pale: proximity to them causes System-ranked individuals to experience what engineers call a *resonance echo* — a brief perception of their own Void Index stat, which is otherwise invisible. Most beings find this experience deeply distressing.

PART FOUR: FLORA & ECOLOGY

Notable Species by Region

IRON COVENANT WORLDS

Greybloom (*Ferrum Anthesis*)

A hardy flowering plant that grows in contaminated industrial soil. Flowers are gray-white, about the size of a human hand. Used medicinally — the extracted oil has analgesic properties effective against Resonance-burn (the injury that occurs when an ability is pushed beyond the user's current capacity). Practically ubiquitous in Covenant medical facilities.

Iron Lichen (*Ferrolithica Communis*)

Grows on exposed metal surfaces — hull plating, structural beams, station exteriors. Extremely resistant to vacuum conditions and radiation. Used as a bioindicator — its color changes in response to air quality, making it a cheap environmental sensor for station habitats. Culturally significant in the Covenant as a symbol of persistence.

Dust Vine (*Aridis Serpens*)

A semi-parasitic vine that grows through cracked pavement, concrete, and compressed earth. Produces no flower. Edible tuber roots. One of the primary food supplements for Unranked and low-rank populations on Covenant industrial worlds where food import costs are high.

AETHON DOMINION WORLDS

Resonance Lily (*Resonantia Floris*)

The cultural emblem of the Aethon Dominion. A flower that grows only in soil with measurable Lattice activity — it is, in effect, rooted in both the physical and Resonance layers simultaneously. The blooms shift color continuously, cycling

through the spectrum based on ambient Resonance levels. High-Resonance environments produce deep violet blooms. Low-Resonance environments produce pale yellow. Used in Aethon ritual spaces as environmental indicators. Considered sacred in some Aethon traditions.

Memory Moss (*Mnemonica Viridis*)

A moss species with an unusual property: it encodes trace chemical information from everything it grows adjacent to. Old Memory Moss colonies are used by Dominion archivists as supplementary record-keeping systems — the moss holds, in chemical form, a record of everything that happened near it for the past several centuries. Reading it requires specialized equipment and significant expertise.

Thought Thistle (*Cogitans Spinosa*)

A thorned plant whose contact produces a mild Resonance stimulation effect in sensitive species (particularly Aethon). Not hallucinogenic — more accurately described as a temporary perception clarity boost. Used in Dominion meditative practices. Mildly addictive in Aethon. Illegal in Covenant territory.

THE GREAT EXPANSE (Deep Space)

Void Kelp (*Vacuus Laminaria*)

A space-native organism that grows in the boundary zones between systems where solar wind interactions create energy-rich particle environments. Not technically alive in the conventional sense — metabolizes radiation rather than chemical energy. Forms vast, slow-moving colonies called *drifts*. Navigation hazard at dense concentrations. Harvested by Velanthi for the radiation-processing enzymes in its cellular structure, which have industrial and medical applications.

Null Spore (*Absentia Fungalis*)

A fungal organism that colonizes derelict ships and stations. Feeds on residual Resonance energy in materials that have been inhabited by ranked beings. Its presence causes a measurable decrease in the ambient Resonance level of any space it occupies. In large concentrations, it can suppress ability usage. The Sovereignty classifies large Null

Spore colonies as navigational hazards and environmental threats. It is, effectively, a natural ability suppressant.

The Slow Gardens (*Aeterna Jardin*)

Not a single species but an ecosystem — a complex of organisms that grows in the gravitational shadow zones of binary star systems. Includes photosynthetic organisms, filter feeders, and predatory species all operating on timescales 10,000x slower than biological norms elsewhere. A Slow Garden that looks static to human perception has undergone decades of ecological activity in the time an observer watches it. Some Slow Gardens are millions of years old. They are protected under Sovereignty ecological law. Entering one is a criminal offense.

PART FIVE: FAUNA & CREATURES

Bestiary — Volume I

RANKED CREATURES

The System does not restrict rank assignment to sapient beings. Animals and semi-sapient creatures with sufficient Resonance sensitivity can and do receive System ranks. Combat with a ranked creature is a legitimate rank advancement pathway. Some of the most dangerous entities in the Sovereignty are not sapient.

VOID WRAITH (Space-native)

Threat Level: A-rank equivalent | Classification: Resonance Predator

Physiology: Non-corporeal in the traditional sense. A Void Wraith exists primarily in the Resonance Lattice and projects a physical presence into material reality only when hunting. Its material form appears as a roughly humanoid shape of compressed dark matter approximately 3 meters tall, with no facial features except two points of intense violet light where eyes would be.

Abilities: *Resonance Drain* — drains ability energy from ranked beings in proximity, weakening abilities and causing Resonance-burn in high-stat targets. *Phase Shift* — can transition between the Lattice and material layers at will, becoming untouchable by physical attacks. *Echo Strike* — attacks that exist simultaneously in the physical and Lattice layers, bypassing standard defenses.

Habitat: Deep Expanse, particularly in Null Spore zones where Resonance density is disrupted. Also found near ruins of pre-Sovereignty civilizations.

Notes: Void Wraiths are not evil — they are predators. They hunt Resonance. They are drawn to high-rank individuals the way apex predators are drawn to large prey.

Encounters in the deep Expanse are common enough that all Expanse-rated ships carry Void Wraith countermeasures.

GRAVITON SHARK (Space-native)

*Threat Level: B-rank equivalent | Classification: Spatial
Predator*

Physiology: A massive, roughly cylindrical organism, 40–80 meters in length, evolved for life in zero-gravity environments. No true skeleton. The body is a series of muscular rings around a central digestive column, with six locomotion fins arranged radially. Can maneuver in vacuum by venting compressed gas through specialized organs.

Abilities: *Gravity Sense* — detects mass distortions with extreme precision, effectively sensing anything with gravitational presence within a 500-meter radius. *Crush Field* — projects a localized gravitational intensification that crushes smaller objects and disrupts spatial perception in organisms.

Habitat: Asteroid belts, debris fields, the gravitational halo regions of gas giants.

Notes: Apex predator of the debris field ecosystem. Graviton Sharks are not Resonance-sensitive — they cannot be detected by standard ability-based scans, only by mass sensors. This makes them a significant hazard for fighters who rely primarily on Resonance perception.

CHAIN BEAST (Planet-native)

Threat Level: C-rank equivalent | Classification: Pack Hunter

Physiology: Quadrupedal, 1.5 meters at the shoulder, six legs arranged in two tripod sets — three front legs and three rear legs, allowing an unusual rolling gait that is faster than it appears. Armored hide, segmented. Head is a mass of sensory organs rather than a distinct face. Pack-forming species; functions at C-rank equivalent in groups of 6+, drops to D-rank equivalent when isolated.

Abilities: *Chain Link* — when two or more Chain Beasts are within 20 meters of each other, they share Resonance — effectively pooling their ability energy. The chain is disrupted when they are separated. *Pursuit Lock* — once a Chain Beast pack selects a target, they track through any

environment with a single-minded focus that does not diminish over distance or time.

Habitat: Industrial wastelands, derelict station exteriors, any environment with complex three-dimensional terrain.

Notes: Common on Covenant outer worlds. Considered a nuisance-level threat for B-rank and above. For Unranked individuals, a Chain Beast pack is a death sentence.

THE RECURSION (Construct? Entity? Classification contested)

Threat Level: SSS? | Classification: ANOMALY — DO NOT ENGAGE

Physiology: The Recursion does not have a consistent physical form. Reports describe it as a region of approximately 10–50 meters in diameter in which physical law does not apply consistently. Objects within the Recursion's influence loop — an action performed inside it repeats. Time within its field replays. The System cannot rank it because the System cannot perceive it consistently.

Known Encounters: Three documented. First: a research vessel in the Expanse that transmitted a distress call consisting of the same 4-second audio clip repeated 847 times before going silent. Second: a Covenant patrol unit that returned to base with no memory of the preceding six months but with rank advancement consistent with six months of continuous combat. Third: a Dominion archive node that began generating perfect copies of documents that did not exist yet.

Notes: Classified at the Sovereignty council level. The dominant theory is that the Recursion is either a pre-Sovereignty construct that malfunctioned catastrophically or an expression of the Endless Dark achieving coherent physical presence. Neither theory is comforting.

PART SIX: POLITICS & GOVERNANCE

The Sovereignty's Political Architecture

The Pentarch Balance

The five Great Powers — the Iron Covenant, the Aethon Dominion, the Vermillion Host, the Velanthi Syndicate, and the Pale Margins (contested) — have maintained a cold equilibrium for approximately 200 years. This equilibrium is not peace. It is managed conflict — a state in which outright war between Pentarch powers is too costly for anyone to initiate while proxy conflicts, economic warfare, and intelligence operations are constant.

The Three Laws of the Pentarch:

1. No Pentarch power may deploy SS-rank or above assets in direct conflict with another Pentarch power without full council notification.
2. No Pentarch power may alter the System's rank protocols without unanimous council approval.
3. The Eternal Seat is neutral ground. Violations of Eternal Seat neutrality are cause for collective response.

All three laws have been violated in the current political period. None of the violations have been formally acknowledged.

The Suppression Compact

Approximately 400 years ago, the Pentarch council reached a classified agreement: any individual identified as carrying Succession bloodline markers would be suppressed at birth — their System rank hidden, their ability development administratively blocked — until the council could determine their disposition.

The official justification: Succession bloodlines carry a destabilization risk to the rank hierarchy that the council has a responsibility to manage.

The actual reason: The last unmanaged Succession individual — a woman named Kira Vael — achieved SSS rank at age 19, walked into the Eternal Seat, and rewrote three foundational System protocols before the council could respond. She was contained after seven months of what historians diplomatically call "significant system instability." The council decided this could not happen again.

Ren Voss is the first Succession bloodline individual to have escaped suppression management since Kira Vael.

Faction Relationships Matrix

			Iron Covenant		Aethon Dominion		Vermillion
Host		Velanthi Syndicate					
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| **Iron Covenant** | — | Cold tension | Proxy conflicts |
Economic competition |

| **Aethon Dominion** | Cold tension | — | Ideological
hostility | Intelligence cooperation |

| **Vermillion Host** | Proxy conflicts | Ideological
hostility | — | Arms trade |

| **Velanthi Syndicate** | Economic competition |
Intelligence cooperation | Arms trade | — |

PART SEVEN:

RELIGION &

PHILOSOPHY

The Major Belief Systems of the Sovereignty

THE SYSTEM FAITH (The Archivists)

Distribution: Primarily Iron Covenant, spread throughout Sovereignty

Core Belief: The System is not a tool — it is a moral framework. Rank is not just a measure of capability; it is a measure of worth. The Architect did not create an administrative system; it created a justice system. High rank means you deserve power. Low rank means you have not

yet demonstrated your right to it. The Unranked are not oppressed — they simply haven't proven themselves yet.

Practices: Rank advancement ceremonies are religious events. Archivists maintain detailed records of all rank advancements in their communities. Death rituals include a final System reading — whatever rank you hold at death is your eternal designation.

Sacred Text: *The Ledger* — a collection of historical rank advancement records with theological commentary, arguing that each recorded advancement demonstrates the Architect's providence.

Controversy: The System Faith is the dominant religion of the Iron Covenant's ruling class and has been accused of being constructed specifically to justify the existing power hierarchy. Archivists reject this accusation vigorously.

THE VOID COVENANT (The Deep Listeners)

Distribution: Fringe settlements, Expanse explorers, Unranked communities

Core Belief: The Endless Dark is not empty. It is the original state — the state before the Architect organized, ranked, and categorized everything. The Deep Listeners believe the System is a cage imposed on a reality that was more free, more fluid, and more honest before it. They do not worship the Endless Dark; they listen to it.

Practices: Meditative practices designed to reduce Resonance output to baseline — the goal is to become, temporarily, invisible to the System. Deep Listeners report that this state produces experiences of contact with something that predates the rank system. They describe these experiences as grief, wonder, and recognition.

Sacred Text: None. Texts are considered System-adjacent — recording, categorizing, ranking. The Void Covenant communicates through oral tradition and symbol.

Controversy: The Sovereignty does not ban the Void Covenant but monitors it closely. There are a disproportionate number of Succession bloodline individuals in Deep Listener communities, though whether this is causal or correlational is a matter of heated academic debate.

THE RESONANCE CHURCH (The Weavers)

Distribution: Aethon Dominion and diaspora communities

Core Belief: The Resonance Lattice is the body of a being so vast it cannot perceive individual sapient life any more than a sapient being can perceive individual cells. Rank advancement is the process of a cell becoming complex enough to brush against the consciousness of the greater being. SSS-rank individuals are cells that have become aware of themselves as part of something larger.

Practices: The Threading — the Aethon practice of direct Resonance connection — has been incorporated as a central religious practice. Weavers conduct communal Threadings during which they attempt to touch the collective Lattice-consciousness together. They describe the experience as contact with something enormously patient.

Sacred Text: *The Weave* — a living document updated by consensus of the highest-rank Weaver councils. It is updated when new information is received through communal Threading. The Sovereignty considers The Weave's "update"

process epistemologically suspicious. The Weavers consider the Sovereignty's opinion epistemologically limited.

THE ASCENDING PHILOSOPHY (The Climbers)

Distribution: The Vermillion Host, fighting communities throughout Sovereignty

Core Belief: Not a religious belief in the supernatural sense — a philosophical position: the only meaningful life is the life spent climbing. Rank advancement is not a means to an end; it is the end. Being is becoming. The moment you stop trying to advance, you begin dying. The goal is not to reach a destination; the goal is the climb itself.

Practices: The Climbers maintain journals called *Ascent Logs* — daily records of perceived growth, challenge, and advancement. They celebrate failure as diagnostic information and disdain both stagnation and certainty.

Sacred Text: None formally, but *The Codex of Ascent* — a collection of philosophical essays written over centuries by Host warriors and scholars — functions as a reference text.

Controversy: The Ascending Philosophy's embrace of failure and uncertainty makes it uncomfortable for the System Faith. The System Faith argues that rank is an objective measure of worth; the Climbers argue that rank is a snapshot of a moment and means nothing about what comes next.

PART EIGHT:

MEDICINE &

PHARMACOLOGY

The Sovereignty's Medical Systems

Standard Medical Technology

Resonance Scanners — The primary diagnostic tool for anything involving ranked individuals. A Resonance Scanner can read all six primary stats, detect injury at the cellular level, identify Resonance-burn, and flag anomalous System readings. Limitations: cannot read suppressed ranks. A suppressed individual appears to a Resonance Scanner as fully Unranked.

Nanite Therapy — Microscopic repair units injected into the bloodstream. Standard treatment for physical injury from rank-tier D upward. The nanites are keyed to the patient's System signature — they will not function in Unranked individuals. The Sovereignty's most visible structural inequality: an injured Unranked person heals slower than a ranked person at the same injury level because their insurance tier does not cover nanite therapy.

Ability Regulation (AR) Protocol — A medical intervention used when an individual's ability is developing faster than their body can sustain. Essentially, a temporary pharmaceutical brake on ability development. Used in young rank advancers who are developing too quickly. Also used, without disclosure, in some suppression cases.

Resonance-Burn Treatment

Resonance-burn is the most common serious injury in the ranked population. It occurs when an ability is pushed beyond the individual's current capacity — the excess Resonance tears through the user's internal Lattice-interface,

causing physical damage that standard instruments read as neural trauma.

Symptoms: Extreme pain, temporary ability loss, cascading stat reduction, in severe cases permanent ability degradation.

Treatment Protocol:

1. *Greybloom Extract* — analgesic for Resonance-specific pain. Works on all species.
2. *Lattice Stabilizers* — pharmaceutical compounds that reduce Resonance throughput, allowing the internal interface to repair without further stress.
3. *Resonance Dialysis* — for severe cases. A machine-assisted process in which the patient's Resonance output is externally mediated while internal repair proceeds.
4. *Guided Rank Suppression* — extreme cases only. Temporarily suppressing the patient's rank to E-tier to eliminate all Resonance demand while the interface heals.

Pharmacopoeia — Notable Substances

Lattice Tea — A colloquial name for a preparation made from dried Memory Moss. Mild Resonance stimulant. Legal. Very common in Dominion territory and Dominion diaspora communities. Produces a state of slightly elevated Resonance sensitivity for 4–6 hours. Popular among researchers and students. Mildly addictive in Aethon; non-addictive in other species.

Void Root Tincture — An extract derived from a root plant found only in certain Expanse systems. Temporarily reduces Resonance signature — the user becomes harder to detect by Resonance-based perception and scanning. Illegal under Sovereignty law. Used extensively by the Syndicate's intelligence services and by those who wish to travel undetected.

Ascendance — A pharmaceutical compound developed (and officially banned) by the Vermillion Host approximately 150 years ago. Artificially elevates stat values by 15–30% for 8–12 hours. The enhancement is real and System-visible. Severe after-effects including stat depression

and, in regular users, permanent stat degradation. The Host uses it in extreme combat situations. The Covenant considers it dishonorable. The Dominion studies it.

Succession Suppressant — The compound administered via chip to Succession bloodline infants. Classified. Its existence is not publicly known. It binds to the System interface in the individual's chip and prevents the Succession abilities from manifesting while appearing, to external observers, as a standard Unranked reading. What happens if the suppressant degrades — as it appears to be doing in Ren Voss — is not documented in any accessible records, because it has not happened before under observation.

PART NINE: TECHNOLOGY & VEHICLES

The Sovereignty's Technological Landscape

The System Chip

Every Sovereignty citizen above Unranked status has a System Chip — a device implanted at birth (for citizens) or at first rank assessment (for immigrants and newly-discovered species). The Chip is the physical interface between the biological individual and the System. It reads stats, transmits rank data, administers rank advancements, and records ability development.

Chip Architecture:

Core Processor — the computational element.

Reads biological data 10,000 times per second.

Resonance Interface — the metaphysical element.

Translates the individual's Lattice interactions into System-readable data.

Broadcast Module — transmits rank data to the System network. Range: effectively unlimited through the Lattice.

Administrative Layer — the part that can be modified by authorized parties. Where suppression protocols are installed.

Chip Removal: Technically possible. Practically equivalent to suicide for ranked individuals — the removal process destroys the Resonance Interface, eliminating the individual's ability to use their abilities permanently.

Chip Modification: Legal only for licensed System Administrators. Illegal modification — including suppression removal attempts — is a Class 1 Sovereignty crime.

Ship Classes

Scrap-Runner (E-rank standard vessel)

Length: 40–80 meters. Crew: 3–12. FTL: short-range only (single system jumps). Armament: minimal defensive. Common in fringe settlements and among Unranked/low-rank independent operators. The kind of ship Ren grew up knowing. Built from salvaged components by necessity.

Interceptor (D/C-rank standard vessel)

Length: 80–150 meters. Crew: 20–50. FTL: medium-range (multi-system). Armament: four forward weapons arrays, two rear defensive. The workhorse of the Covenant's enforcer class. Fast, lightly armored, designed to catch and disable rather than destroy.

Cruiser (B/A-rank standard vessel)

Length: 300–600 meters. Crew: 200–800. FTL: long-range (cross-sector). Armament: full weapons suite including area-effect options. The standard capital asset of mid-tier Pentarch operations.

Dreadnought (S-rank+ standard vessel)

Length: 2–5 kilometers. Crew: 5,000–20,000. FTL: unlimited range. Armament: includes Resonance Cannons — weapons that fire concentrated ability energy rather than physical projectiles. Devastating against ranked targets. Three dreadnoughts constitute a show of force that no Pentarch power will ignore.

The Eternal Throne's Flagship — *Axiom

Length: 12 kilometers. Crew: classified. Only vessel in the Sovereignty built to SSS-rank specifications. Its weapon systems have never been used in recorded history. Its existence is the reason the three-law equilibrium has held.

Personal Equipment

Resonance Armor — Personal armor for ranked individuals. Not purely physical — contains a Lattice-interfacing layer that supplements the wearer's own defensive abilities. Ranked at the same tier system as

individuals. D-rank armor provides basic ability enhancement. S-rank armor is the most advanced personal protection in the Sovereignty.

Void Blades — Melee weapons containing a compressed Null Spore element that disrupts Resonance in the strike zone. A Void Blade hit causes Resonance-burn on contact rather than just on ability overextension. Preferred weapon of Syndicate operatives who need to neutralize ranked opponents quickly.

System Jammer — Illegal technology that creates a local field suppressing System Chip broadcast functions. Within the field, no one's rank data transmits. No one can be identified by the System. Widely used in black markets and criminal operations. The Covenant spends significant resources trying to suppress their distribution.

PART TEN:

CULTURES, COLORS &

AESTHETICS

Visual Design System

Rank Colors (Official System

Designation)

Rank	Primary Color	Secondary	Usage	
-----	-----	-----	-----	
Unranked	No color / Ash Gray	—	Chip glow	absent
E	White	Silver	Chip glow dim white	
D	Cobalt Blue	Ice Blue	Chip glow steady blue	
C	Emerald Green	Jade	Chip glow steady green	

| B | Gold-Yellow | Amber | Chip glow warm gold |

| A | Burnt Orange | Deep Amber | Chip glow deep orange |

| S | Crimson Red | Deep Red | Chip glow bright red |

| SS | Violet | Deep Purple | Chip glow violet, visible at distance |

| SSS | Black and White simultaneously | — | Chip does not glow — chip disappears |

Faction Aesthetics

Iron Covenant

Primary Colors: Iron gray, deep red accents, black

Materials: Heavy metal, industrial polymer, functional over decorative

Architecture: Brutalist and massive. Buildings built for permanence and structural integrity, not aesthetics. Interior spaces are organized for efficiency. Natural light is considered a luxury.

Fashion: Uniform-derived. Rank insignia prominent. Colors correspond to rank tier. Civilians in Covenant space dress functionally — elaborate clothing is associated with the Dominion and considered performative.

Symbol: A closed fist within a gear

Aethon Dominion

Primary Colors: Deep teal, silver, white, with Resonance Lily violet accents

Materials: Living materials (wood, plant-composite, cultivated stone), glass, Aethon-woven fabric that shifts color subtly with ambient Resonance

Architecture: Organic forms. Curves preferred over angles. Buildings incorporate living elements — gardens, moss walls, bioluminescent panels. Spatial design intended to facilitate Resonance flow.

Fashion: Layered, flowing, color-coded by specialty rather than rank. Academics wear deep teal. Administrators wear white. The Threading caste wears silver.

Symbol: An open eye with Resonance filaments extending from the iris

Vermillion Host

Primary Colors: Deep crimson, black, bone white

Materials: Combat-grade materials, scarred and marked deliberately. In Host culture, damage to equipment is a record — it is not repaired unless it compromises function.

Architecture: Fortified always. Even civilian spaces in Host territory have defensive considerations built in. Living spaces are personal spaces — Host culture considers communal living weak.

Fashion: Marked. Every Host fighter maintains a visual record of their significant battles on their armor or body. Scars are considered aesthetic achievements. Artificial scars are a significant insult.

Symbol: A flame consuming a chain

Velanthi Syndicate

Primary Colors: No consistent palette — adaptability is the aesthetic principle. Syndicate operatives are trained to visually match their environment.

Materials: Light, adaptable, multi-function. Every piece of Syndicate equipment does at least three things.

Architecture: The Velan Drift habitats are a maze deliberately — designed to be navigable only by those who know the routes. Outsiders describe them as chaotic. Velanthe describe them as efficient.

Fashion: Chromatophore-display clothing that shifts with the wearer's actual emotional state. In Velanthe culture, attempting to hide your emotional display through clothing is considered offensive.

Symbol: Eight lines radiating from a central point, each a different color

PART ELEVEN:

LANGUAGE & NAMING

CONVENTIONS

The Sovereignty's Linguistic Architecture

Galactic Standard

A constructed lingua franca approximately 800 years old, evolved from the integration of the four original Pentarch languages. All official Sovereignty business, System interfaces, and inter-faction communication uses Galactic Standard. Galactic Standard is tonally flat, precision-optimized, and deliberately stripped of the ambiguity present in native faction languages.

Naming Conventions by Faction/Species

Human (Covenant style): Given name + clan name.

Clan names often industrial or geographic in origin.

Examples: Ren Voss, Kael Dross, Vera Holt.

Aethon: Single true name + Threading designation (added after first Threading ceremony, typically at age 12–15). True names are short, vowel-heavy. Threading designations are longer and describe the quality of one's Resonance filament pattern. Example: Aeva Thane (true name: Aeva; threading designation: Thane, meaning *clear-bright*).

Keth: Clan name first, then battle name (earned through first significant combat). Before earning a battle name, a Keth uses their clan name only. Battle names are verbs — they describe an action the individual is known for. Example: *Massiva-Breaks* (clan: Massiva; battle name: Breaks).

Velanthi: A birth identifier (typically a geometric shape concept) plus a display-name (chosen, changeable, describes

current primary emotional state or life-phase). Example: *Circle-of-Grief* (birth identifier: Circle; display-name: of-Grief, currently in mourning).

Key Terms Glossary

The Eternal Hierarchy — The System and everything it administers. The formal term for the Sovereignty's governance philosophy.

Succession — The bloodlines carrying Endless Dark affinity. Abilities sourced from below the Lattice. The thing the council fears.

Resonance-burn — Injury from over-extending abilities.

Threading — The Aethon practice of direct Resonance connection between individuals.

The Scrap Quarter — Generic term for the lowest-tier habitation zones in any Covenant-administered facility. Where Ren Voss grew up.

WRAITH — The AI intelligence embedded in Ren's System Chip. Origin: unknown. Function: unknown. It calls Ren *the Asset*.

The Endless Dark — The layer beneath the Resonance Lattice. Older than the System. Source of Succession power.

The Pale — The non-ranked entities encountered in deep Expanse space. No System designation. No classification.

The Architect — The entity that created and administers the System. Not seen. Not heard directly. But present.

End of Master Sourcebook Volume I

*Next Volume: Locations & Dungeons, Extended Bestiary,
Faction Adventure Hooks, Campaign Frameworks*

VOID ASCENDANT: THE ETERNAL HIERARCHY

MASTER SOURCEBOOK — VOLUME II

**Locations, Dungeons, Extended Bestiary,
Vehicles, Weapons & Technology**

PART THREE:

LOCATIONS & STAR SYSTEMS

The Sovereignty's Core Worlds

VERATH PRIME — The Throne World

System: Verath System, Galactic Core Adjacency Zone

Classification: Ecumenopolis (Planet-City)

Population: 14.7 billion registered; estimated 3–4 billion
unregistered

Gravity: 1.2 Standard

Atmosphere: Maintained by continent-spanning
atmospheric processors (Class IX)

Climate: Controlled. Perpetual temperate across upper
tiers; lower tiers run hot from industrial exhaust.

Verath Prime is the undisputed center of Sovereignty power. The entire surface is built over — layer upon layer, going down eleven kilometers into the planetary crust. The upper three layers (the Pinnacle Districts) are home to A-rank and above. The middle layers (Transit Zones, Commercial Rings) house the working B and C-ranks. Everything below Layer 7 is called the Deep, and it operates by different rules.

Notable Districts:

The Spire of Arbitration — The Sovereignty Council's seat of government. A single tower rising 4 km above the upper layer. Access requires B-rank minimum; top floors require S-rank escort.

The Resonance Academies — Seven competing institutions for ranked ability development. The top two (Aurelius and Thessan) only accept A-rank potential candidates.

The Scrap Quarter Network — The collective term for all Deep-level habitation zones. Ren Voss's home district, Sublevel 9-West, is one of ~800 such zones.

The Black Concourse — Layer 5. The largest unregulated market in the Sovereignty. Everything illegal is sold here. The Covenant looks the other way in exchange for 30% of transaction taxes.

The Vault of First Ascension — A sealed facility beneath Layer 10. The original location where the Architect first manifested the System 4,000 years ago. Off-limits. Guarded by six S-ranks permanently.

Power Infrastructure:

Verath Prime runs on a network of 847 Resonance Tap Stations — facilities that draw ambient Resonance energy from the Lattice and convert it to usable power. Each station is maintained by a team of B-rank Resonance Engineers. If more than 30 stations fail simultaneously, the atmospheric processors begin to degrade. The Succession has theorized about this weakness extensively.

KETH'MARA — The War World

System: Outer Massiva Cluster, Frontier Zone

Classification: Fortified Combat World

Population: 890 million (80% military or military-adjacent)

Gravity: 1.6 Standard

Atmosphere: Breathable but thin. High UV. Most inhabitants have adapted over generations.

Climate: Harsh. Seasonal temperature swings of 80°C. Constant storm activity in the polar regions.

The homeworld of the Keth species. The Sovereignty absorbed Keth'Mara 600 years ago — technically a treaty, practically a conquest. The Keth fought harder than any species the Sovereignty had ever encountered and lost only because the Architect refused to grant rank advancement to non-System-registered species until they joined. The Keth joined. They have not forgiven.

Notable Locations:

The Proving Grounds of Massiva — A 900 km² combat training facility. The most brutal rank-advancement testing environment in the Sovereignty. 23% fatality rate for C-to-B advancement trials.

The Bone Archives — A Keth cultural institution housing the preserved remains of every Keth warrior who died unranked. Considered sacred. The Sovereignty attempted to demolish it once. The resulting uprising killed 40,000 Sovereignty soldiers.

The Breach — A 2 km wide scar in the planet's surface from a Succession assault 200 years ago. It has never been repaired. The Keth keep it open as a reminder.

Clan-Hold Massiva-Prime — The fortress of the largest Keth clan. Houses 180,000 Keth. Built into a mountain range. Has resisted six Sovereignty "compliance operations."

ASHA'LEN — The Drift World

System: The Expanse Fringe, coordinates classified by the Aethon

Classification: Mobile Habitat Cluster (technically a world; practically a fleet)

Population: 2.1 million Aethon

Gravity: Variable (sections range from 0.3 to 0.9 Standard)

Atmosphere: Each hab-module maintains its own environmental system

Asha'Len is not a planet. It is a collection of 400+ interconnected habitat modules, asteroid-anchored stations, and converted vessels that the Aethon have linked together over 800 years of gradual accumulation. It drifts through a specific corridor of the Expanse, following a path that the Aethon claim is determined by Resonance currents visible only to them.

Notable Locations:

The Thread Halls — The central linking structure. Where the collective Resonance of all Aethon aboard merges into a shared awareness. Non-Aethon visitors describe it as walking through music they can feel but not hear.

The Remembrance Garden — An artificial ecosystem sustaining 847 plant species from the Aethon homeworld (destroyed 1,200 years ago). The most protected location in the cluster.

The Calculation Spire — Where Aethon mathematicians map the Resonance Lattice. Their charts are more accurate than anything the Sovereignty produces, and they do not share them.

The Silence Wing — A section of Asha'Len that broadcasts no Resonance signature. Where Aethon go when they need to think without the collective. Outsiders are never admitted.

CRUCIBLE STATION — The Arena World

System: Neutral Zone, The Expanse Edge

Classification: Orbital Combat-Commerce Platform

Population: 3.4 million permanent; 800,000 transient

Gravity: 0.9 Standard (station-generated)

Atmosphere: Maintained. Breathable by all major species.

Crucible Station is the largest independent facility in the known galaxy — not affiliated with the Sovereignty, the

Dominion, or any faction. It operates under the Charter of Neutral Commerce, a document drafted by the six founding merchant houses 300 years ago and enforced by the station's own military arm (the Crucible Guard, ~40,000 strong, averaging B-rank).

Districts:

The Ring Markets — 11 concentric commercial rings. Everything legal, semi-legal, and quietly illegal. The largest information brokerage in the galaxy (The Glass Archive) operates from Ring 4.

The Pit — The combat arena. The official version is ranked competition. The unofficial version runs three levels underground and has no rules. Orin Dusk owns Level 3.

The Dock Sprawl — 2,400 berths for vessels up to destroyer class. Capital ships anchor in external docking arms.

The Quiet District — Where factions meet when they don't want records. Surveilled by everyone. Recorded by no one (officially).

The Underbelly — The maintenance tunnels and sub-levels. Effectively a second city. Population estimated at 200,000 permanent unlicensed residents.

THE DOMINION WORLDS

Primary World: VESK TERMINUS

Classification: Industrial Fortress World

Population: 8.2 billion

Notable Feature: The entire planet surface is covered in weapons manufacturing. The Dominion produces 40% of the Sovereignty's military hardware — and sells the other 60% to whoever can pay.

The Dominion is not a rebel faction. It is a sanctioned competitor within the Sovereignty framework — a bloc of twelve worlds that achieved enough economic power to negotiate semi-autonomy 400 years ago. They pay Sovereignty tithes. They follow Sovereignty law. They simply also do whatever they want within their own borders.

Secondary Worlds:

Vesk Null — A gas giant with 14 processing stations. Fuel production. 90% of faster-than-light capable vessels in the galaxy refuel from Vesk Null derivatives.

The Gray Stations — 40 orbital facilities scattered through Dominion space. Manufacturing, research, weapons testing. Three of them are off the Sovereignty's official maps.

Kira's Fall — A dead world. Was a Succession stronghold. The Dominion glassed it 80 years ago. No survivors. The Dominion does not discuss why they were the ones who did it instead of the Sovereignty.

Deep Expanse Locations

THE PALE REACHES

The outermost regions of mapped space. Beyond B-rank standard patrol range. The Resonance Lattice behaves differently here — thinner in some areas, impossibly dense

in others. The Pale (unranked entities) originate from somewhere in this region. No expedition sent to find their origin point has returned.

Hazard Classification: OMEGA (Sovereignty designation for locations where rank-based protections do not apply normally)

Key Features:

The Signal Corridor — A 40-light-year stretch where a repeating signal has been broadcasting for at least 2,000 years. No one has decoded it. The Aethon refuse to discuss it.

The Collapse Zones — Regions where the Resonance Lattice has catastrophically failed. Physical laws become unreliable. Ships passing through report crew members developing spontaneous ability manifestations — or losing the ones they had.

The Architect's Scar — A region of space where instruments detect what appears to be a massive scar in the Lattice itself. As if something the size of a solar system was violently removed. The Architect has never responded to queries about it.

THE RUIN FIELDS

Ancient structures scattered throughout the Expanse. Pre-System civilization remnants. No consistent architectural language — they were not all built by the same civilization.

The Six Major Ruins (Named):

1. **The Ossuary of Keth'Vor** — A station-sized structure built entirely from compressed biological material. Still produces heat.

2. **The Lattice Engine** — A device the size of a moon that appears designed to modify the Resonance Lattice directly. Non-functional. Every faction has attempted to activate it.

3. **The Cartographer's Library** — Contains star charts for 40,000 systems not in any Sovereignty database. Most of the charted systems, when visited, are empty. Some are not.

4. **The Throne Without Sovereign** — A single room inside an otherwise featureless asteroid. The room contains a chair. Anything that sits in the chair hears the Endless Dark.

5. **The Graveyard of Giants** — 847 vessels, each the size of a continent, drifting in formation. No life signs. No damage. No explanation.

6. **The Mirror Station** — A facility that exactly replicates whatever station is nearest to it. Currently adjacent to Crucible Station. The replica is perfect down to the inhabitants — except they are all dead.

PART FOUR:

DUNGEONS &

ENCOUNTER ZONES

Dungeon Design Philosophy

In VOID ASCENDANT, "dungeons" are not simply underground corridors. They are any bounded environment where the normal rules of civilization do not apply — places where rank advancement trials occur, where ancient tech goes active, where the Void bleeds through. They range from urban choke points to ancient ruins to the interior of living entities.

DUNGEON: THE SUBLEVEL WARREN

Location: Beneath any major Covenant city

Threat Level: F-rank entry, D-rank recommended

Recommended Party Size: 3–6

Primary Hazards: Criminal factions, malfunctioning tech, collapsed infrastructure, occasional Lattice-dead zones (abilities suppressed)

Overview:

The infrastructure maintenance tunnels beneath Covenant cities. Officially, they are utility corridors. Unofficially, they are the Sovereignty's forgotten underbelly — home to unlicensed residents, black-market operations, and occasionally something that crawled up from deeper. Every city has them. None of them are fully mapped.

Level Structure:

Surface Layer (SL-1): Active utility conduits. Patrols twice per standard cycle. Minor criminal activity. Low threat.

Mid-Level (SL-2 to SL-5): Where unlicensed populations live. Complex social hierarchies. The Covenant doesn't enter without significant force.

Deep Level (SL-6 to SL-9): Abandoned sectors. Structural instability. Relic tech from pre-System era. Something has been moving in SL-8 for the past three months. No one has confirmed what.

The Sub-Dark (SL-10+): Below the official plans. The Resonance Lattice is wrong here. Thick. Like wading through it. Entities that emerge from here are not in the System's database.

Key Encounter Nodes:

1. **The Broken Gate** — A deactivated security checkpoint. Someone has manually welded it open. Beyond it: SL-7. Cause of weld: unknown.

2. **The Market Below** — SL-3. 200+ stalls. Everything from bootleg rank-advancement supplements (dangerous, ~40% effective) to weapons without serial numbers to information. The market boss: a C-rank former Covenant enforcer who defected.

3. **The Lattice Pool** — SL-8. A location where Resonance has pooled physically — it's visible as a

faintly luminous liquid collecting in a low point. Drinking it has unpredictable effects. Bathing in it has caused two documented spontaneous rank advancements and one documented dissolution of self.

4. **The Archive Room** — SL-9. Someone has been collecting records here for a very long time. The records predate the System. The handwriting matches no known species.

DUNGEON: THE PALE INCURSION ZONE

Location: Any frontier territory; specific instance: Sector 7, Fringe Zone

Threat Level: B-rank minimum. A-rank recommended.

Recommended Party Size: 5–8

Primary Hazards: The Pale (entities), Lattice degradation, reality anchor failure, Succession resonance bleed

Overview:

When the Pale breach into normal space, they do not simply attack. They *change* the space they occupy. The Resonance Lattice begins to degrade. Technological systems built on Resonance principles fail or behave unexpectedly. The affected zone becomes progressively more hostile to ranked individuals the longer the Pale remain.

Stage Progression (Incursion develops over time):

Stage 1 (Hours 0–6): Pale Scouts. C-rank equivalent. Lattice slightly distorted. Tech functions normally.

Stage 2 (Hours 6–24): Pale Hunters. B-rank equivalent. Lattice noticeably distorted. 20% ability failure rate.

Stage 3 (Days 1–3): Pale Shapers. Attempting to restructure local space. A-rank threat equivalent. 50% ability failure rate. Physical reality begins to exhibit minor anomalies (gravity fluctuation, light behavior changes).

Stage 4 (Days 3+): Pale Sovereign. Single entity. S-rank equivalent. The zone is now Pale-space.

Standard combat doctrine has no recommended response. Evacuation protocol only.

Key Encounter Nodes:

1. **The Breach Point** — Where they came through. Closing it requires either A-rank reality-anchor deployment or a Succession bloodline individual (their affinity can touch what opened it). The Covenant will never admit this.

2. **The Changed Zone** — Area already restructured by Stage 3 Pale. Physical laws are suggestions here. Anything killed here does not stay dead unless the breach is closed first.

3. **The Pale Shrine** — A structure the Pale have built or revealed. It resonates on a frequency below the Lattice. Standing next to it causes vivid memories of things that have not happened yet.

DUNGEON: THE DOMINION

BLACK SITE

Location: Gray Station 7, Dominion Space

Threat Level: C-rank entry, B-rank recommended

Recommended Party Size: 4–6

Primary Hazards: Elite Dominion security, experimental weapon systems, test subjects

Overview:

The Dominion does not officially conduct human experimentation. Their Black Sites conduct *enhanced rank-advancement research* — a distinction that the individuals inside would dispute. These stations are heavily secured, poorly mapped, and contain things the Dominion does not want extracted.

Facility Structure:

Exterior Docking/Security: 40 Dominion Iron Guard (C-rank minimum). Two automated defense systems. Biometric locks keyed to senior Dominion personnel only.

Research Level Alpha: Standard weapons R&D. Relatively normal. The scientists here know they work for a weapons manufacturer. They're fine with it.

Research Level Beta: Where enhanced subjects are kept. Individuals who underwent experimental rank-advancement procedures. Some succeeded, gaining capabilities outside the System's standard parameters. Most did not. The ones who didn't are still alive, which is part of what makes Beta complicated.

Research Level Omega: Classified. The official manifest says it doesn't exist. The power consumption data says otherwise. It consumes more energy than the rest of the station combined.

PART FIVE: THE EXTENDED BESTIARY

Classification System

All entities are classified along three axes:

Rank Equivalent: F through S (measures threat to a single ranked individual)

Lattice Relationship: Positive (uses Resonance), Neutral (ignores it), Negative (consumes/degrades it), Void (exists below the Lattice)

Origin: Natural (evolved), Constructed (built/engineered), Emergent (arose from Lattice phenomena), Ancient (predates the System)

STANDARD THREAT ENTITIES

THE PALE

Rank Equivalent: Scout: C | Hunter: B | Shaper: A |
Sovereign: S+

Lattice Relationship: Negative (active degradation)

Origin: Unknown. Possibly Ancient. Possibly something else entirely.

The Pale are the most dangerous recurring threat in the known galaxy. They are not animals. They are not intelligent in any conventional sense — they do not negotiate, do not flee, do not respond to any ranked ability in a predictable way. They are white. Not albino — white in a way that suggests the absence of color is a choice, or a property, rather than a biological trait. Their forms vary: some are vaguely humanoid, some are geometric, some are large enough to engulf a starship. They share one consistent feature: the Resonance Lattice dies around them.

Combat Notes:

Standard ranked abilities have reduced effect (30–70% depending on Pale tier and Lattice degradation in area)

Physical weapons function normally; energy weapons powered by Resonance systems may fail

Pale Hunters exhibit tactical awareness; they will identify the highest-ranked individual in a group and focus

Pale Shapers do not attack directly; they restructure the environment to make combat impossible

The only confirmed effective counter above B-rank: Succession bloodline abilities, which operate below the Lattice

Behavior Notes:

They do not eat. They do not appear to reproduce in any observed manner. They breach from somewhere. They do whatever they're doing. They leave or they don't. No Pale has ever been captured alive — not because they fight to the death, but because containment systems consistently fail in their proximity.

VOID-SCARRED

Rank Equivalent: D to A (varies dramatically based on base rank and degree of scarring)

Lattice Relationship: Negative (uncontrolled emission)

Origin: Emergent — ranked individuals whose System Chip has been damaged or corrupted

Void-Scarred are ranked individuals whose connection to the Resonance Lattice has become unstable. Their System Chip no longer regulates their abilities properly. The result is a being that emits Resonance uncontrollably, burning through its own biological systems in the process. They are not undead. They are dying, very slowly, while becoming increasingly dangerous.

Stages of Scarring:

Stage 1 (Marked): Visible Resonance bleed from the System Chip site. Abilities fluctuate. Personality

changes — increased aggression, reduced impulse control. Still rational. Still capable of conversation.

Stage 2 (Burning): Resonance emissions visible at all times. Uncontrolled ability discharges. Rationality compromised. Will attack ranked individuals instinctively — their degraded chip reads all active Resonance as a threat.

Stage 3 (Fallen): No rational function remains. Body is partially dissolved by uncontained Resonance. What remains is an ability-emission engine with enough biological structure to move and seek targets. The original person is gone.

Notable: The Covenant classifies Void-Scarred as a public health threat and authorizes lethal removal at all stages. The Covenant does not publicize how many Stage 1 Scarred exist in the Deep levels of its cities, living quietly, managing their condition, terrified of being reported.

RESONANCE FAUNA — EXPANSE

MEGABEASTS

THE LATTICE LEVIATHAN

Rank Equivalent: S

Lattice Relationship: Positive (draws from ambient Resonance)

Origin: Natural (evolved in Expanse deep space)

Size: 40–200 km in length

The apex predator of the Expanse. Not a ship. Not a construct. A living organism that evolved in the void of space, feeding on concentrated Resonance nodes. Their biology is unlike anything evolved in atmosphere — no bones, no conventional organs, a distributed nervous system that is 40% Resonance-active tissue. They move by directly manipulating local space using their Resonance organs. They are not aggressive toward ships unless the ship is emitting a strong Resonance signature — which puts all ranked individuals at risk.

The Problem: An S-rank individual's full-power ability output can attract a Lattice Leviathan from 30 light-minutes away.

Combat Notes (for the extremely committed):

Hull weapons (non-Resonance-based) deal normal damage

A coordinated fleet action has killed Leviathans twice in recorded history

Their defensive response — a Resonance pulse — can damage or destroy System Chips within 2 km

Succession abilities may allow communication (one documented incident; the record is sealed)

THE VOID LAMPREY

Rank Equivalent: B

Lattice Relationship: Void (below Lattice)

Origin: Ancient

Size: 3–12 meters

A predator that exists partially in the space below the Resonance Lattice. It can shift between material space and the space between the Lattice and the Endless Dark at will. Conventional weapons pass through it when it is in its shifted state. Resonance-based weapons are ineffective — it feeds on them. The only reliable counter: abilities that touch the Void layer, or Succession blood.

Appearance: When visible, a cylindrical organism covered in sensory filaments, with a radial mouth that opens to six segments. When feeding, its entire body becomes faintly luminous. Beautiful in a deeply alarming way.

Habitat: Anywhere the Lattice is thin. They congregate in Collapse Zones. Occasionally appear in lower levels of Covenant cities where the infrastructure has damaged the Lattice over decades of energy extraction.

THE ECHO SWARM

Rank Equivalent: C (individual) | A (full swarm)

Lattice Relationship: Positive (mimicry)

Origin: Emergent

Size: Individual 0.3 meters; swarm 10–500 meters
(combined)

Single organisms of no particular threat. In groups of 200+, they develop emergent behavior: collective intelligence, coordinated attacks, and — most alarmingly — Resonance ability mimicry. An Echo Swarm that has observed a specific ability being used can produce a crude approximation of that ability using coordinated biological action.

The Tactical Problem: An Echo Swarm that has observed an S-rank ability demonstration can produce a B-rank equivalent of that ability. And there are a lot of them.

CONSTRUCTED ENTITIES

SOVEREIGNTY ENFORCER UNITS (SEUs)

Rank Equivalent: D to B (model dependent)

Lattice Relationship: Positive (Resonance-powered)

Origin: Constructed

The Sovereignty's frontline security automation. Not fully autonomous — each unit operates under a handler's oversight. Built with integrated Resonance weapons systems, structural durability rated against C-rank physical impacts, and a target acquisition AI updated quarterly.

Models:

SEU-3 (Standard): D-rank equivalent. Mass deployed. Crowd control.

SEU-7 (Combat): C-rank equivalent. Deployed for anti-insurgency. The primary tool of Covenant enforcement in Deep Level operations.

SEU-ALPHA (Elite): B-rank equivalent. Only deployed on direct Council authorization. Each unit costs more than a mid-tier warship.

PHANTOM Unit (Classified): Rumors only. Allegedly A-rank equivalent. No confirmed sightings. Three individuals who claimed confirmed sightings are unavailable for comment.

WRAITH-CLASS CONSTRUCTS

Rank Equivalent: Varies (classification pending)

Lattice Relationship: Anomalous (below standard Lattice signatures)

Origin: Unknown

WRAITH — the intelligence embedded in Ren Voss's System Chip — is not the only one of its kind. It is, however, the only one that is confirmed functional and communicative. Others have been found: in ruins, in decommissioned Covenant deep-research stations, in one

case inside the Sovereignty Council's own sealed archives. None of the others responded to query. WRAITH has not explained why it is different.

What is known: WRAITH-class constructs are not built on Resonance principles. They operate on something else. The Architect does not acknowledge them when queried. This is notable because the Architect acknowledges everything.

PART SIX: VEHICLES & VESSELS

Ship Classification System

All vessels in Sovereignty space are classified by the System's own framework — which assigns a Combat Power rating (CP) to ships the same way it assigns ranks to individuals. This is both practically useful and philosophically interesting.

VESSEL CLASSES

SKIFF CLASS (CP: 10-50)

Crew: 1–4

Length: 15–40 meters

FTL Capable: No (standard); Modified skiffs with jury-rigged FTL exist but are illegal and dangerous

Primary Use: In-system transport, short-range patrol, personal craft

The working vehicle of the galaxy. Every docking station has hundreds. They are to starships what motorcycles are to vehicles — fast, exposed, and not rated for anything serious.

Notable Variants:

Scrap Runner — The standard unlicensed version used in Deep Level operations. No transponder. Maximum interior cargo space. Zero comfort.

Covenant Interceptor Skiff — The fast-pursuit variant used by Covenant enforcement. Rated for C-rank operator; has Resonance-boosted engines that respond to the pilot's rank signature.

The Ghost — A custom variant. Coated in signal-absorbing material. No Resonance signature. Used by intelligence operatives and extremely paranoid individuals.

FRIGATE CLASS (CP: 200-800)

Crew: 40–200

Length: 150–400 meters

FTL Capable: Yes (standard jump drive)

Primary Use: Patrol, escort, fast attack

The bread-and-butter of Sovereignty military presence. A well-crewed frigate with a B-rank captain is a significant threat to anything short of a capital ship. The Dominion's frigate variants are notably superior in raw firepower; the Covenant's are superior in longevity and Resonance-integrated systems.

Notable Variants:

Sovereignty Lancer-Class — The standard military frigate. Resonance-integrated targeting, crew quarters rated for 90, three main weapon batteries.

Dominion Hammer-Class — Pure firepower. Minimal crew comfort. The Dominion believes comfort is an enemy of readiness.

Keth Warspear-Class — Smaller, faster, built for boarding actions. Keth naval doctrine emphasizes getting personnel aboard enemy ships over long-range engagement.

Crucible Free Frigate — No standard design. Modified civilian vessels armed to frigate-equivalent rating. Variable but often surprisingly effective.

CRUISER CLASS (CP: 1,500-5,000)

Crew: 500–2,000

Length: 600–1,200 meters

FTL Capable: Yes (jump drive + one emergency micro-jump per 12 hours)

Primary Use: Fleet backbone, extended operations, force projection

A cruiser can operate independently for six months without resupply. It is the minimum vessel class for a Sovereignty Admiral's flag. A single cruiser in orbit can engage in sustained planetary bombardment sufficient to sterilize a continent.

CAPITAL CLASS (CP: 10,000+)

Crew: 5,000–80,000

Length: 2,000–40,000 meters

FTL Capable: Yes (dedicated jump drive; can create micro-FTL bubbles for escorted vessels)

Primary Use: Fleet command, theater-level force projection, orbital siege

Only seven capital-class vessels exist in the known galaxy. Each one is effectively a city. Each one has a name. Each one has a history. When a capital-class ship appears in a system, the politics of that system change.

Named Capital Vessels:

1. *The Sovereign Will* — Sovereignty Council flagship. 38,000 meters. Never been in direct combat. Its presence alone has ended three wars.

2. *The Iron Absolute* — Dominion capital ship. 28,000 meters. Has been in direct combat seventeen times. Shows it.

3. *The Nameless* — Registration unknown. Last documented sighting: Expanse fringe, forty years ago. Believed destroyed. Believed.

4. *The First Covenant* — The oldest vessel of its class. 4,100 years old. Pre-System. Still functional. The Sovereignty does not know how.

GROUND VEHICLES

RESONANCE CYCLES

Personal transport. A standard Resonance Cycle operates by generating a low-level Resonance field beneath

the rider, providing frictionless movement at up to 300 km/h on flat terrain. They are keyed to their owner's System Chip signature — a stolen cycle is a useless cycle. High-end models can be modified for riders with specific ability types, acting as an amplifier platform during movement.

IRON CRAWLERS

Heavy ground transport. Used by the Keth as their primary military ground vehicle. Articulated tracks, hull rated against B-rank physical impacts, crew of 6–10. The Keth version has an open fighting platform on top — they consider enclosed fighting positions to be a sign of poor character.

THE SOVEREIGN'S BLADE (Vehicle)

A specialized single-operator combat platform used by S-rank Sovereignty enforcers. Not a vehicle in the traditional sense — it's a wearable frame that amplifies the operator's abilities by routing power through the System Chip. An S-rank individual in a Sovereign's Blade is classified as a strategic asset equivalent to a frigate.

PART SEVEN:

WEAPONS &

TECHNOLOGY

Weapon Categories

RESONANCE WEAPONS

The dominant technology of the Sovereignty. Weapons that use the Resonance Lattice as their operating medium.

Type I — Resonance Pulse Emitters:

Standard ranged weapon. Generates a directed pulse of Resonance energy. Effect on target depends on their rank: F-rank target receiving a B-rank pulse will be reduced to component matter. B-rank target receiving the same pulse will experience reduced ability function for 4–8 hours. A-rank targets are minimally affected. S-rank targets must be

hit with S-rank Resonance weapons, which require S-rank operators.

Type II — Lattice Disruptors:

Specialized weapons designed to damage the Resonance connection between a target and the Lattice. Effectively a weapon designed to disable rank-based abilities without necessarily killing. Considered "humane" by Covenant doctrine. Considered deeply threatening by anyone who relies on their abilities for everything.

Type III — Resonance Blades:

Melee weapons with integrated Resonance channels. A Resonance Blade concentrates the wielder's ability output through the blade edge, allowing rank-commensurate cutting capability against rank-hardened targets. An A-rank warrior with an A-class Resonance Blade can cut through materials that would stop a standard frigate's broadside.

Type IV — Void Weapons (Restricted):

Weapons that operate below the Resonance Lattice. Developed by capturing and studying Succession ability

output. Classified by the Sovereignty at the highest level. Officially do not exist. A Void Weapon affects targets regardless of rank — the A-rank hardening that protects against standard weapons does not apply. Three confirmed examples exist. All three are in Sovereignty Council custody. Two of them work.

CONVENTIONAL WEAPONS

Technology predating the System. Still effective against unranked individuals and low-rank targets. Irrelevant against A-rank and above under standard conditions.

Kinetic Accelerators (Railguns): Magnetically accelerated projectiles. High mass, high velocity. Against F and E-rank targets, lethal. Against D-rank and above with active ability reinforcement, negligible. Against S-rank, genuinely irrelevant. However — kinetic weapons work in Lattice-dead zones where Resonance weapons fail. This is their primary tactical value.

Chemical Propellant Weapons: Archaic. The Keth still use them in ceremonial contexts and keep functional versions because they work in environments that destroy Resonance-based systems. Practical wisdom dressed as tradition.

TECHNOLOGY SYSTEMS

THE SYSTEM CHIP

The fundamental technology of Sovereignty civilization. A sub-centimeter biotech implant placed at the base of the skull during the ranking ceremony. It:

- Interfaces directly with the nervous system and the Resonance Lattice

- Administers rank advancement protocols (testing, verification, advancement)

- Regulates ability output (prevents involuntary ability discharge in standard conditions)

Provides the System's UI (the floating display panels, rank information, ability descriptions visible to the individual)

Serves as personal identification, financial account, communication device, and health monitor

Vulnerabilities:

Can be damaged by Void-origin attacks

Can be corrupted by sustained Lattice disruption (Void-Scarred condition)

Can be hacked (theoretically; in practice requires S-rank technical ability or Succession-level Void access)

Ceases to function in areas where the Lattice is completely absent

WRAITH Exception: Ren Voss's System Chip hosts WRAITH, an intelligence that operates independently of the Lattice. This should not be possible. The Architect has not commented.

FASTER-THAN-LIGHT TRAVEL (JUMP DRIVE)

FTL travel in the VOID ASCENDANT universe operates through the Resonance Lattice itself. A Jump Drive generates a Resonance bubble that temporarily places the vessel in the Lattice layer — where distances are compressed relative to material space — and then re-emerges at a calculated destination.

Mechanics:

- Jump range is limited by drive rating and available Resonance energy

- Jump accuracy decreases with distance; long jumps require navigational corrections

- Cannot jump within a planetary gravity well (minimum safe distance: 4 planetary radii)

- Cannot jump inside Lattice-dead zones or Pale-incursion areas

- Jump drives are rank-rated: a B-rank drive operated by an A-rank pilot performs at A-rank parameters

Void Jump (Classified): The Succession has theorized a method of transit through the Endless Dark rather than the Lattice. It would have no range limits and no Lattice dependency. It would also require the navigator to touch the Endless Dark directly. The Covenant considers this line of research approximately as alarming as it sounds.

RESONANCE COMMUNICATION (RESCOM)

The standard communication technology. ResCom transmissions travel through the Lattice at speeds far exceeding light — galactic-scale communication with acceptable delays (minutes to hours depending on distance). In Lattice-dead zones, ResCom fails completely. In Pale-incursion areas, ResCom becomes unreliable. In the Endless Dark, there is no ResCom, but things hear you anyway.

THE CARTOGRAPHER NETWORK

An AI-administered navigation system that maintains positional data for all registered vessels and jump destinations throughout Sovereignty space. Run by a non-ranked intelligence (one of the few major AIs in regular use — the Sovereignty is cautious about AI following an incident 200 years ago that the records describe only as "the Cartographer's Error" and do not elaborate on).

End of Volume II

*Next Volume: Flora, Fauna, Medicine, Religion, Politics,
Economics, Culture, Campaign Frameworks*

VOID ASCENDANT: THE ETERNAL HIERARCHY

MASTER SOURCEBOOK — VOLUME III

**Flora, Fauna, Medicine, Religion,
Politics, Economics, Culture & Campaign
Frameworks**

PART EIGHT: FLORA OF THE VOID ASCENDANT UNIVERSE

Classification Framework

All plant-equivalent life forms are classified by:

Resonance Index (RI): 0 (inert) to 10 (highly active Resonance interaction)

Lethality Class: Passive / Reactive / Active / Predatory

Distribution: Which worlds/environments they appear in

Commercial Value: None / Low / Moderate / High / Restricted (controlled substance or strategic resource)

SOVEREIGN SPACE FLORA

LATTICE VINE (*Resonara velantis*)

RI: 7 | **Lethality:** Passive | **Distribution:** Temperate worlds, Covenant-administered parks

Commercial Value: High (medicinal, decorative, ceremonial)

A climbing plant with translucent stems that visibly pulse with faint Resonance light. Grows toward Resonance-active individuals rather than light sources. Covenant nobility cultivate elaborate lattice vine gardens as status symbols — a garden where the vines grow toward you indicates your rank. Medically, the concentrated sap (Lattice Essence) is the primary ingredient in rank-advancement stabilizers — supplements that reduce the risk of Resonance-burn during advancement trials.

Appearance: 3–8 meter climbing stems, translucent jade-white, with small star-shaped flowers that emit faint luminescence during high Resonance periods (typically dawn). The flowers change color based on the rank of nearby individuals: silver-white near F-rank, gold near B-rank, deep violet near S-rank.

Cultivation Notes: Will not grow in Lattice-dead zones. Will not grow near Succession bloodline individuals — it turns brown and withdraws. No one in the Covenant will officially comment on why this is useful as a detection tool.

VOID BLOOM (*Vacuus florentis*)

RI: 0 | **Lethality:** Passive (flowers) / Reactive (root structure)

Distribution: Expanse fringe worlds, deep ruins sites

Commercial Value: Restricted

A plant that grows in Lattice-thin environments where most Resonance-active life cannot survive. Its root structure actively consumes trace Resonance from the soil, creating small dead zones around mature specimens. The flowers are extraordinarily beautiful: large, midnight-black petals that seem to absorb light, with a single central filament of pure white that glows regardless of ambient light conditions.

Medical Use: Void Bloom pollen, refined, is used in small doses as an ability suppressor — it temporarily reduces Resonance output, used medically to treat Resonance-burn and in forensic contexts to subdue Void-Scarred Stage 1 individuals. In large doses it produces a complete ability shutdown for 4–8 hours. The Covenant classifies it as a controlled substance. The black market value of refined Void Bloom extract is extraordinary.

Cultural Note: The Aethon revere the Void Bloom. They believe it grows where the Lattice has been wounded by grief — where something of significant Resonance died. Their funeral traditions include planting Void Bloom seeds at sites of significant loss.

IRONWOOD CANOPY (*Ferrum arborex*)

RI: 3 | Lethality: Passive | **Distribution:** High-gravity worlds, Keth'Mara specifically

Commercial Value: High (construction, weapons)

The dominant tree species of Keth'Mara. Grows in canopy formations 60–90 meters tall, with bark that has been reinforced over millennia by the planet's intense UV radiation and the trace Resonance in the soil. Ironwood is, without hyperbole, one of the most structurally dense organic materials in the known galaxy. A mature Ironwood log can absorb a C-rank kinetic impact without fracturing.

Uses: Keth ceremonial weapons are carved from Ironwood. They are not decorative — Ironwood weapons with proper shaping can remain effective against D-rank targets. The Sovereignty has attempted to patent and industrialize Ironwood harvesting; the Keth have made clear, repeatedly and physically, that the Ironwood forests are not a resource to be extracted.

Ecological Note: Ironwood canopies host approximately 340 dependent species unique to Keth'Mara, including three sapient or near-sapient organism types that the Sovereignty has not officially classified because classification would complicate development rights.

DRIFT KELP (*Vacuus marina expansia*)

RI: 5 | Lethality: Reactive | **Distribution:** Deep Expanse
(grows in gas giant atmospheres and nebula edges)

Commercial Value: Moderate (fuel refinement, medical)

An organism that lives in the gas layers of uninhabited worlds and nebula edges — it feeds on ambient electromagnetic and Resonance energy directly, requiring no soil. Drift Kelp forms massive floating colonies, some hundreds of kilometers across. Ships passing through Drift Kelp colonies experience system interference — the kelp's

Resonance absorption affects instruments and, at density, begins to affect System Chips.

The Reactive Lethality: At sufficient concentration, Drift Kelp will respond to a concentrated Resonance source (such as an active ability) by suddenly compressing — the entire colony contracts toward the source. Vessels have been lost this way. The compression force of a mature Drift Kelp colony is equivalent to a B-rank crushing ability.

Fuel Application: Rendered Drift Kelp produces a fuel additive that increases jump drive efficiency by 12–18%. The Dominion has Drift Kelp harvesting operations throughout the Expanse fringe. The harvesting vessels are purpose-built with non-Resonance propulsion systems for obvious reasons.

THE REMEMBRANCE BLOSSOM

(*Memoria aeterna*)

RI: 8 | **Lethality:** Passive | **Distribution:** Aethon
Asha'Len exclusively; extremely rare elsewhere

Commercial Value: Restricted (Aethon protect it absolutely)

A flowering plant from the Aethon homeworld, now cultivated exclusively in the Remembrance Garden aboard Asha'Len. Small (15–30 cm), with petals that cycle slowly through every visible color over a 24-hour period. RI of 8 — it actively broadcasts a gentle Resonance signal that the Aethon describe as "the feeling of being remembered."

Properties: Extended proximity (72+ hours) to Remembrance Blossoms produces measurable changes in the Resonance profile of nearby individuals — specifically in the emotional-memory centers of the nervous system. Aethon use them in healing practices, particularly for trauma recovery. Non-Aethon exposed for extended periods report vivid, emotionally clear memories of events they had suppressed or forgotten.

The Restricted Classification: The Sovereignty classified Remembrance Blossoms as a controlled substance after a Covenant intelligence operative exposed to one for 96 hours unexpectedly recalled, with perfect clarity, classified operations they had been medically suppressed to forget. The Aethon's response to the classification notice was, reportedly, musical.

GREY MOSS (*Cinerea lattus*)

RI: 1 | Lethality: Active (slow) | **Distribution:**
Covenant city deep levels, ruins, abandoned stations

Commercial Value: None (significant hazard)

A grey-green moss that grows on any surface, thriving in low-light, low-Resonance environments. In small quantities, harmless. In the quantities found in deep urban environments, a serious hazard: Grey Moss produces spores that, when inhaled, gradually colonize the respiratory

system and establish a very faint Resonance-absorbing colony in the lungs. The host doesn't notice for months. By the time symptoms appear (reduced endurance, slowly degrading ability output), the colony is established.

The Treatment: Lattice Vine essence, administered at sufficient concentration, kills Grey Moss colonies. Free in theory. Expensive in practice — Lattice Essence is a controlled substance administered through Covenant medical facilities. Deep Level residents have developed unlicensed folk remedies of variable effectiveness.

The Social Dimension: Grey Moss exposure is a reliable indicator of poverty. Covenant officials know this. The correlation between Grey Moss lung and proximity to unregulated habitation is published in Sovereignty medical literature. The funding to address the environmental conditions that produce Grey Moss exposure is not published anywhere.

DANGEROUS FLORA

THE LATTICE TRAP (*Resonara vorax*)

RI: 9 | **Lethality:** Predatory | **Distribution:** Expanse fringe worlds

Commercial Value: Extremely High (restricted, research only)

A sessile predator that mimics the Resonance signature of a rank-advancement opportunity — specifically, it broadcasts a signal that registered System Chips interpret as a high-value Resonance deposit. When a ranked individual approaches to investigate, the Lattice Trap activates: a radius of Lattice-disruption that disables the target's abilities, followed by physical capture using fibrous root-tendrils that emerge from the soil.

The plant doesn't eat its prey immediately. It keeps them alive for weeks, slowly draining the Resonance from their System Chip — the stored advancement potential — as a

nutrient source. The individual feels their rank degrading. This takes time.

The Lattice Trap is the only known organism that can reduce a ranked individual's rank tier. The Sovereignty's bioweapons research division would very much like a living specimen. They have sent seventeen expeditions. Seven returned with specimens. None of the specimens survived transport. The researchers are confident this is accidental.

PART NINE: FAUNA OF THE VOID ASCENDANT UNIVERSE

The Rank-Adapted Megafauna

THE RESONANCE HOUND (*Canis resonantia*)

Rank Equivalent: D (domestic) to B (wild apex variant)

Distribution: Temperate Sovereignty worlds; bred domestically across the galaxy

Status: Domesticated (most breeds); Wild (apex variant, Expanse fringe)

The most common companion animal in the Sovereignty. Resonance Hounds evolved alongside ranked civilization — they are sensitive to Resonance signatures in a way that makes them extraordinarily effective trackers, guard animals, and companions for ranked individuals. A Resonance Hound can detect the signature of a specific individual's rank profile from 2 kilometers in ideal conditions.

Breeds:

Scout Hounds: Fast, lean, long-snout, bred for tracking. The Covenant uses them for fugitive retrieval.

Guard Hounds: Heavily built, with passive Resonance-hardened musculature equivalent to their owner's rank (they adapt to their primary bonded individual). A Guard Hound bonded to a B-rank owner is a B-rank-hardened animal.

Thread Hounds: An Aethon-bred variant capable of perceiving Resonance Threading — they can sense when an Aethon is in distress through their bonded connection. Used as emotional support animals with genuine utility.

Wild Apex: The undomesticated ancestor. Twice the size of domestic breeds. Packs of 8–20. They hunt in coordinated Resonance-suppression waves — the pack collectively emits a low-level Resonance disruption that weakens prey's abilities before physical engagement.

THE IRON BEETLE (*Coleoptera ferrum massiva*)

Rank Equivalent: E (individual) to C (swarm)

Distribution: Keth'Mara exclusively

Status: Wild; Protected (Keth law)

A beetle the size of a human fist, with a carapace that incorporates trace Resonance-active minerals from Keth'Mara's soil. The carapace achieves D-rank hardness in mature specimens. In swarms of 500+, the beetles coordinate: their collective carapace surfaces form a

reflective array that redirects Resonance-based attacks back at the source, at reduced efficiency.

The Keth have an expression: *"The Iron Beetle does not defeat its enemy — it makes its enemy defeat itself."* It is applied to the Iron Beetle. It is also applied to the Keth's general military philosophy.

THE PALE MOTH (*Lepidoptera vacua*)

Rank Equivalent: F (individual) | **Classification:**
Anomalous (swarm behavior)

Distribution: Pale Incursion zones, Lattice-dead areas

Status: Wild; Avoid

Individually, a small luminescent flying insect. Notable only for their habitat preference (they thrive in Lattice-thin environments) and their bioluminescence (they glow on the same frequency as Void Bloom flowers). A single Pale Moth is harmless.

A swarm of Pale Moths is a warning. They congregate before Pale incursions — appearing in Lattice-thin areas hours to days before the Pale themselves arrive. No one has established a causal relationship. The correlation is 94% across all documented incursions. Frontier settlements that have learned to read Pale Moth behavior have higher survival rates than those relying on System-based detection alone.

The Anomaly: In extremely large swarms (10,000+), Pale Moths have been documented exhibiting a collective behavior with no individual analog: they form a shape. The shape is always the same. No one has confirmed what the shape represents. The Aethon recognize it. They will not say from where.

THE VOID SERPENT (*Serpens abyssi*)

Rank Equivalent: A

Distribution: Sub-Lattice spaces; occasionally emerges in ruins sites

Status: Apex predator; Do Not Engage (standard doctrine)

An entity that exists primarily in the space between the Resonance Lattice and the Endless Dark — the same layer that Void Lampreys inhabit, but the Void Serpent is apex predator of that layer. It surfaces into material space to feed, typically targeting high-Resonance individuals. Its bite injects a compound that temporarily inverts the target's Resonance polarity — their abilities begin affecting themselves rather than external targets.

Appearance: When in material space: a serpentine form, 8–25 meters, with scales that seem to be made of compressed darkness — they absorb light but emit a faint deep-violet luminescence from between the scales. The eyes are white. It is the only thing with white eyes that does not concern the Pale — they ignore Void Serpents completely, which is the most alarming thing about both of them.

PART TEN:

MEDICINE &

PHARMACOLOGY

The Medical System of the Sovereignty

Overview

Sovereignty medicine operates on two parallel tracks:

1. **Resonance Medicine:** Treating rank-related conditions, ability injuries, System Chip complications. The dominant medical paradigm. Requires medical personnel with at minimum D-rank to practice effectively.

2. **Conventional Medicine:** Treating biological conditions unrelated to rank. Widely practiced, widely available to all levels of society. Notably, conventional medicine is generally better in

Sovereignty space than Resonance Medicine — it has had centuries of investment and doesn't require specialized practitioners.

The disparity in access: Resonance Medicine is expensive, controlled, and available primarily through Covenant-licensed facilities. A Void-Scarred Stage 1 individual seeking treatment must go to a Covenant facility, which will report them. A person with Grey Moss lung in the Deep Levels may not be able to reach or afford a licensed facility. Conventional medicine for standard illness is cheap and available everywhere. Resonance Medicine for rank-related conditions is the exclusive tool of those with means.

PHARMACOLOGICAL COMPENDIUM

LATTICE STABILIZER (Common Names: "Stabler," "Blue Cap")

Type: Resonance Medicine

Source: Refined Lattice Vine essence + synthetic compounds

Legal Status: Controlled (prescription required; widely available on black market)

Effect: Reduces Resonance-burn risk during ability use, stabilizes System Chip function during advancement trials. Standard pre-advancement supplement. The difference between a 23% and a 12% fatality rate in advancement trials is largely Lattice Stabilizer access.

Side Effects: Mild Resonance-output reduction for 6 hours post-dose. Mild drowsiness. Dependency with prolonged use (30+ consecutive doses) — abrupt discontinuation causes severe Resonance instability.

Black Market Note: Unlicensed versions ("Street Stable") are 40% effective and carry a 12% risk of accelerating the very instability they're meant to treat.

RESONANCE SURGE COMPOUND

(Common Names: "Rush," "The Edge," "Apex")

Type: Resonance Medicine (off-label stimulant use)

Source: Synthetic

Legal Status: Illegal (Schedule I)

Effect: Temporarily elevates Resonance output by 40–80% above baseline. Lasts 2 hours. Used illegally by combatants seeking a temporary rank boost.

Side Effects: Severe Resonance-burn following the effect period. Risk of System Chip corruption with repeated use. Three documented cases of spontaneous ability reversal (ability began destroying the user rather than external targets). Highly addictive.

Cultural Note: Rush is endemic in the Pit at Crucible Station. The unregulated fighting circuit has essentially normalized it. Most combatants who fight in the deep circuits for more than two years have System Chip damage.

VOID BLOOM EXTRACT (Common Names: "Null," "The Quiet")

Type: Resonance Medicine (and weapon)

Source: Refined Void Bloom pollen

Legal Status: Restricted (Covenant medical use only; black market premium)

Effect (Medical Dose): Reduces Resonance output by 60% for 4–6 hours. Used to treat acute Resonance-burn, allow System Chip recovery, and (in Covenant forensic contexts) subdue unstable individuals.

Effect (Combat Dose): Reduces Resonance output by 95% for 8–12 hours. Functionally disables rank-based abilities. A combat-dose delivery to an S-rank individual does not reduce their physical capability (which is extraordinary regardless) but eliminates everything beyond physical.

Side Effects (Medical): Fatigue, emotional flatness, mild memory consolidation disruption.

Side Effects (Combat Dose): All of the above, severe. Some individuals describe the experience as "being unmade." The emotional resonance of complete ability loss for a ranked individual is comparable to temporary

blindness in a sighted person — it is deeply traumatic, not merely inconvenient.

RANK-GROWTH SERUM (Common Names: "Climb," "The Ladder," "Heaven Step")

Type: Resonance Medicine (enhancement)

Source: Classified (Covenant R&D)

Legal Status: Illegal (prohibited under Sovereignty Rank Integrity Acts)

Effect: Artificially elevates the Resonance-readiness markers that the System reads during advancement assessment. Does not actually develop the individual's ability or Resonance integration — it games the System's evaluation. The result is artificial rank advancement: the individual advances in tier but their actual capability does not match the new rank's expectations.

Danger: The System assigns tasks, opponents, and combat scenarios commensurate with assessed rank. An

individual who has falsely advanced to B-rank will be treated as B-rank by everyone and everything — including B-rank threats. The failure rate is catastrophic. The mortality rate of individuals who use Rank-Growth Serum more than once: 87% within 18 months of second use.

Why It Exists: Because the social benefits of rank are so significant — employment, housing, social status, access — that people die trying to skip the process.

THE AETHON REMEDIES

The Aethon practice a medical tradition entirely separate from Sovereignty pharmacology. Their medicines operate by adjusting Resonance flow through the body — not the blunt-force approach of Sovereignty Resonance Medicine, but a precise, threading-based practice that treats Resonance disruption the way a conventional doctor treats circulatory blockage.

Thread-Alignment Treatment: An Aethon healer extends their Threading ability into a patient and manually

realigns disrupted Resonance pathways. Effective for Resonance-burn, System Chip stress, and early-stage Void-Scarring. The Sovereignty has attempted to license and mass-produce this treatment. The Aethon position: you cannot mass-produce the attention and skill of a trained healer. The Sovereignty position: we can try.

The Bloom Bath: Extended immersion in a pool infused with Remembrance Blossom extract. The treatment for severe psychological trauma — the Resonance signature of the Blossom interacts with the patient's emotional-memory centers, making suppressed experiences accessible and processable. The Sovereignty considers this a psychic invasion technique and has made it illegal outside Aethon medical contexts. The Aethon consider the Sovereignty's position on this approximately as valid as the Sovereignty's position on anything.

PART ELEVEN:

RELIGION & BELIEF

SYSTEMS

The Major Theological Traditions

THE COVENANT OF THE ARCHITECT

Followers: ~40% of ranked Sovereignty citizens; official state religion

Core Belief: The Architect is the universe's designer, the System is its gift, and rank advancement is the path to fulfillment of cosmic purpose.

The Covenant of the Architect is less a traditional religion than a civilizational philosophy with ceremonial structure. Its core claims are: the universe has a designed purpose, that purpose involves conscious beings developing

their potential, the System is the mechanism by which that development is measured, and achieving S-rank is the closest a mortal can come to fulfilling cosmic intent.

Tenets:

1. **The Architect Wills Advancement** — Growth is sacred. Stagnation is sin.

2. **Rank is Revelation** — Your current rank is an honest measure of your development. Accepting this is the beginning of wisdom.

3. **The Hierarchy is Truth** — The rank hierarchy reflects the genuine order of capability. To resent those above you is to resent reality.

4. **Service is the Path** — Serving those of higher rank while developing your own accelerates cosmic purpose.

Critique (Widely Circulated in Deep Levels): The Covenant of the Architect is a theology purpose-built to make inequality feel inevitable and morally correct. Its primary beneficiaries are A and S-rank individuals. It was formalized 200 years after the Sovereignty consolidated power. These facts are related.

The Architect's Actual Position: The Architect, when queried about the Covenant of the Architect, responds: *"This query is outside System parameters."* This response is interpreted differently by different people.

THE HOST TRADITION

Followers: ~25% of Sovereignty citizens; dominant in frontier zones and among explorers

Core Belief: Existence is a test. The Architect grades. The goal is not rank — it is the quality of choices made regardless of rank.

The Host Tradition emerged from the frontier cultures that the Sovereignty absorbed over three centuries. Its defining characteristic is the rejection of the Covenant's hierarchy-affirming theology: in the Host Tradition, an F-rank individual who chooses correctly is more spiritually advanced than an S-rank individual who does not.

The Three Tests:

1. **The Test of Capacity** — Are you developing what you have? Not maximally — sincerely.
2. **The Test of Choice** — Do you act rightly when it costs you?
3. **The Test of Witness** — Do you see others accurately, without rank bias?

Practice: Host tradition communities maintain Witness Halls — spaces without rank indicators, where individuals are addressed only by name, never by rank. The Sovereignty has occasionally attempted to regulate Witness Halls. The results have consistently been disproportionate to the apparent threat.

Notable: The Host Tradition is the dominant religious tradition among Keth who have adopted religion at all. The Keth modification: The fourth test is the Test of Endurance. You are not judged by whether you win — you are judged by whether you stood.

THE SUCCESSION CREED

Followers: All confirmed Succession bloodline individuals; many unranked Deep Level residents

Core Belief: The System is a cage. The Endless Dark is freedom. The Architect is a jailer. Rank is a chain.

The Succession Creed is not a religion in the conventional sense — it is a cosmological claim held with religious intensity. Its assertion: the organized universe (the Resonance Lattice, the System, the Sovereignty) is a structure imposed on the Endless Dark by an entity (the Architect) whose motives are control, not uplift. The Succession bloodlines are the Endless Dark reasserting itself. Their development is not advancement — it is return.

The Creed's Promise: When the Succession fulfills its purpose, the Lattice will dissolve, the System will end, and consciousness will return to the Endless Dark — free from the hierarchy, free from rank, free from the Architect's grading.

The Ambiguity: The Succession Creed does not specify whether individual consciousness survives this return. Most adherents interpret "freedom" as including personal continuity. A minority interpretation: the freedom is not of the individual, but of the universe itself. The individual is the medium, not the beneficiary. This minority interpretation is not popular, but it may be correct.

THE VELANTHI PATH

Followers: All Velanthi; approximately 8% of non-Velanthi citizens

Core Belief: Consciousness is plural. The self is a current state, not a permanent identity. Death is a display-name change.

The Velanthi do not fear death the way species with fixed identity concepts do. They believe that what they call the "birth identifier" (the core geometric concept of self)

persists through and beyond biological death, cycling through new display-names across multiple existences. What the System calls rank is, in the Velanthei view, merely one display-name period — the "of-Power" phase, eventually succeeded by something else.

Practice: Velanthei maintain extensive genealogical records not of bloodlines, but of birth-identifier chains — tracking the reappearance of geometric self-concepts across generations. When a Velanthei child exhibits characteristics associated with a historical birth-identifier, that lineage is acknowledged and the records are updated.

The Sovereignty's Position: The Velanthei Path is classified as a "cultural tradition" rather than a religion to avoid the administrative complexities of treating it as a faith. The Velanthei find this distinction meaningless and mildly amusing.

PART TWELVE:

POLITICS &

GOVERNANCE

The Sovereignty Structure

THE COUNCIL OF NINE

The governing body of the Sovereignty. Nine members, each holding one of nine permanent seats. The seats are not elected — they are held until death, resignation, or removal by a supermajority of the other eight.

Current Seat Distribution:

Seat One (The First): Traditionally held by the highest-ranked individual in Sovereignty space. Currently an S-rank whose name is not public record. Their decisions are final on matters of military action.

Seats Two–Four: Held by the heads of the three oldest noble houses (families with unbroken A-rank lineage for 10+ generations).

Seats Five–Six: Held by the Directors of the two largest Resonance Academies (Aurelius and Thessian).

Seat Seven: The Covenant Seat — the senior representative of the religious establishment.

Seat Eight: The Commerce Seat — held by election among the fifty largest trading entities in Sovereignty space. Currently held by a Dominion-aligned merchant house. The other Council members find this uncomfortable.

Seat Nine: The Wild Seat — traditionally given to an outsider. Has been held by an unranked individual exactly once (for eleven days, 200 years ago, before the circumstances of their appointment were "clarified"). Currently held by the senior Aethon representative, which the Aethon consider exactly as binding as they choose.

How Laws Are Made: A majority of five passes standard legislation. Military action requires six. Modification of the rank system requires eight. No action has ever required eight votes. The Architect has been

queried about whether it would comply with a Council-ordered modification of the rank system. It has not responded.

THE FACTION POLITICAL LANDSCAPE

The Covenant: The governmental arm of the Sovereignty. Administers the military, the rank system, civil law, Resonance infrastructure. Primary agenda: stability, hierarchy preservation, and the slow absorption of any independent power into its framework.

The Dominion: Twelve worlds of semi-autonomous industrial and military power. Not in rebellion — in constant low-level negotiation. Primary agenda: maintain and expand their economic position. They will do business with anyone. They have standards about who they'll do business with personally, but commercially, the standards are negotiable.

The Host: Not a formal political entity. A loose network of frontier worlds, independent stations, and unaffiliated communities that share the Host Tradition philosophy and a general preference to be left alone. Their political engagement is primarily defensive — they do not seek to govern the Sovereignty; they seek to prevent the Sovereignty from governing them.

The Aethon Collective: A sovereign political entity that the Sovereignty recognizes as an autonomous partner. In practice: the Aethon do what they want. The Sovereignty has accepted this because the Aethon's Resonance mapping capabilities are irreplaceable and the Aethon have made clear they will not share those capabilities with a Sovereignty that treats them as subjects. The relationship is mutually beneficial and mutually resentful.

The Keth Clans: Not unified. Individual clans range from fully Sovereignty-integrated (Clan Massiva-Complies, a designation chosen by the clan itself with obvious irony) to actively hostile (Clan Massiva-Breaks, currently in the sixth year of armed resistance to a specific Covenant administrative decision).

The Succession Network: Not a state. A distributed cell structure of individuals sharing bloodline, ideology, and the conviction that the System must end. They have no capital, no official leadership (WRAITH may be their logistics intelligence; they do not confirm this), and no military force that the Sovereignty can find, which is more alarming than a military force the Sovereignty could locate and engage.

PART THIRTEEN:

ECONOMICS

The Resonance Economy

OVERVIEW

The Sovereignty's economy runs on Resonance. This is not metaphor — the primary currency is Resonance Credits (R-Credits), which are backed by a verifiable store of Resonance energy maintained by the Architect (the only institution anyone trusts to hold the reserve). R-Credits are administered through the System Chip — every purchase, every wage payment, every financial transaction goes through the Chip.

The Implications:

Unranked individuals and those with deactivated/damaged Chips operate outside the formal economy

The Sovereignty can monitor all financial activity

The Succession and Deep Level economies run on physical goods, barter, and unlicensed Resonance-energy tokens ("Black Credits") that the Covenant intermittently attempts to suppress

KEY ECONOMIC SECTORS

Resonance Energy Production: The largest sector.

Generating, storing, and distributing Resonance energy for infrastructure, manufacturing, and transportation.

Controlled largely by the Covenant with significant Dominion involvement.

Rank-Advancement Services: The second largest sector.

Academies, training facilities, advancement supplements, consultants, pre-trial preparation. An entire industry built

on the single most valuable thing in the Sovereignty: the possibility of moving up. The Academy system alone is estimated at 12% of Sovereignty GDP.

Defense and Weapons: Third largest. The Dominion dominates this sector. Produces for the Sovereignty military, private security, independent operators, and — quietly — anyone else who can pay.

Information Brokerage: Formally small. Actually enormous. The Glass Archive at Crucible Station is estimated to handle more economic activity than the entire manufacturing sector of three mid-tier Sovereignty worlds. Information about who is advancing in rank, who has Void-Scar exposure, which noble houses are in financial trouble, what the Succession is planning — this information is worth extraordinary amounts.

The Deep Economy: Unquantified by official statistics. The economic activity of the unranked and the Deep Level residents: barter, unlicensed services, Black Credits, informal lending networks, community support structures that predate the Sovereignty's administration. The Covenant's

best estimate: approximately 8% of total economic activity.
The actual figure is likely three times that.

PART FOURTEEN:

CULTURE & SOCIETY

Colors, Aesthetics & Visual Language

THE RANK COLOR SYSTEM

The Sovereignty uses a formalized color code for rank visibility — clothing, vehicle markings, facility access indicators, and public signage all incorporate rank colors.

Rank	Primary Color	Accent	Common Material Association
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F	Ash grey	None	Rough-spun, recycled fabric
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| E | Dull bronze | Copper | Standard-grade
synthetics |

| D | Steel blue | Silver | Mid-grade manufactured
goods |

| C | Forest green | Gold | Quality-manufactured |

| B | Deep crimson | White | Premium materials |

| A | Imperial gold | Black | Luxury, custom-made |

| S | Void black with white Resonance shimmer | All
| Unique, often ability-modified |

The Deep Level Rejection: In Scrap Quarter communities, the rank color system is deliberately inverted or mocked. F-rank residents often incorporate gold and black into their clothing as an explicit statement. Covenant enforcement technically has regulations about "rank color misrepresentation," but enforcing them in the Deep Levels is not worth the cost.

ARCHITECTURE & DESIGN PHILOSOPHY

Covenant Architecture: Vertical. The higher your rank, the higher your floor. Maximum visible distinction between levels. Clean surfaces, strong geometry, Resonance channels built into structural elements that pulse with the ambient light frequency of the local rank population. Beautiful in a way that explicitly communicates hierarchy.

Keth Architecture: Horizontal. Spread across terrain, built into natural features, prioritizing defensibility and communal space over height. No private rooms — the Keth concept of "privacy" is temporal, not spatial. Individual time, not individual space.

Aethon Architecture: Connective. The hab-modules of Asha'Len are designed to be linked, joined, expanded. No permanent walls between occupied spaces — dividers are temporary and reconfigurable. The aesthetic goal is to make the interior feel like the exterior of nothing, suspended in a flowing medium.

Dominion Architecture: Functional aggression. Every structure communicates: this was built to serve a purpose and the purpose was not your comfort. Clean lines, maximum utility density, visible structural components. The Dominion aesthetic philosophy: if it looks built, it is built.

Deep Level Architecture: Accumulated. Nothing was designed. Everything was adapted, added to, repurposed, layered. The Deep Levels of Covenant cities are palimpsests of human need — you can read the history of a district's poverty or resilience in the layers of its walls.

MUSIC & ARTS

Sovereignty High Culture: Resonance Composition — music created by trained practitioners who use their ability output to directly modulate Resonance fields in performance spaces. Listeners experience music that is simultaneously

heard and felt at a cellular level. The greatest Resonance Composers are A-rank; their performances can temporarily alter the emotional states of everyone in the venue. Access to live Resonance Composition: expensive and controlled by social networks.

Keth Music: Percussion-dominant. The Keth aesthetic principle: music should be work. Their compositions require physical effort from performers — the audience understands that the sound was earned. Keth music sounds like industry, like weather, like something large moving.

Aethon Music: Harmonic threading. Aethon music is literally the expression of Resonance through sound — their performances involve four to twelve practitioners Threading simultaneously, with the music emerging from the interaction of their combined Resonance fields. Non-Aethon who have experienced Aethon live performances consistently report the same effect: they remember things. Clearly. Things they had not known they remembered.

Deep Level Music: Urgent, adaptive, diverse. Every Deep Level has its own evolving musical tradition drawing

from every culture that was pushed there. The result is a musical culture of extraordinary richness that the Sovereignty's official cultural institutions do not document and do not fund. It is also the music that everyone, eventually, is actually listening to.

CUISINE

The Sovereignty Standard: Resonance-processed food. Mass production through Resonance cooking technology produces nutritionally complete food cheaply and quickly. It tastes like nothing. It is everywhere. It is what everyone in the Deep Levels eats when they can't afford anything else.

Keth Cuisine: Raw, cooked over open flame, or fermented for extended periods. The Keth relationship with food is about provenance — you should know what the thing was before it was your meal, and you should respect it. Keth cuisine is intense, often challenging to non-Keth

palates, and deeply tied to seasonal and ecological rhythms of Keth'Mara.

Aethon Cuisine: Precision and patience. Aethon meals are experiences — each dish is designed to produce a specific emotional state through the combination of flavor, texture, aroma, and the faint Resonance-active properties of Aethon-cultivated ingredients. An Aethon formal meal takes eight hours. An Aethon informal meal takes two hours. An Aethon fast meal takes forty minutes, and they apologize for the rush.

The Black Concourse Food Culture: The most diverse food culture in the Sovereignty. Every species and culture has a vendor. Nothing is regulated for authenticity. Everything is regulated for safety (theoretically). The Black Concourse produced the only cuisine that all species eat voluntarily, in defiance of their cultural preferences, because someone down there found flavor combinations that transcend species origin.

PART FIFTEEN:

CAMPAIGN

FRAMEWORKS

TTRPG Adventure Frameworks

FRAMEWORK 1: THE UNRANKED RISING

Premise: Player characters are F or E-rank residents of a Deep Level district. Their community is threatened: a Void-Scar outbreak, a Covenant relocation order, a Succession cell operating in their area, or a Pale incursion reaching their level.

Tone: Street-level survival. The politics of genuine poverty. Every resource matters. Rank-based solutions are unavailable — the PCs must solve problems with what they have.

Progression: The campaign tracks the community's survival while the characters develop toward their first genuine rank-advancement trial. The goal is not to become powerful — it's to get to the starting line of power.

Key NPCs:

The District Elder: An ancient E-rank who has survived everything and trusts no one new

The Covenant Contact: A C-rank enforcer who grew up in this district and is compromised between duty and loyalty

The Succession Whisperer: Someone in the community who is receiving Succession communication. May or may not know it.

The Pale Scout: Has been present in Level 8 for three weeks. Has not attacked. Is watching.

FRAMEWORK 2: THE CRUCIBLE CIRCUIT

Premise: Players are independent operators based out of Crucible Station. They take contracts from various factions (Sovereignty, Dominion, independent, criminal) and navigate the factional politics of neutral space.

Tone: Morally complex action. Every faction has valid points. Every faction will use you and discard you if it's convenient. The game is not "who are the good guys" — the game is "who can I trust, right now, for this job."

Progression: The players build reputation with various factions, eventually reaching a point where they must choose a side in a conflict that will reshape galactic politics — or try to avoid choosing, which is itself a choice.

Key Factions Active in This Framework:

Crucible Station management (pragmatic neutrality; actually just pro-commerce)

A Sovereignty intelligence cell (polished, professional, ruthless)

A Dominion procurement division (friendly, practical, and purchasing something that should not be purchased)

The Glass Archive (sells information to everyone; knows something about WRAITH)

The Succession cell operating through Crucible's Quiet District

FRAMEWORK 3: THE EXPANSE EXPEDITION

Premise: Players are part of an expedition into the deep Expanse. Sovereign-funded (or independent). Goal: the Cartographer's Library, or the Lattice Engine, or something the funder has not been fully honest about.

Tone: Discovery horror. The Expanse is beautiful and deeply wrong. Every ruin contains something the players weren't ready to find. The Pale are present, but the Pale are not the most alarming thing encountered.

Progression: Each major discovery unlocks another layer of the universe's true history. The players came looking for treasure or knowledge. They find out why the universe is the way it is. Whether that knowledge is survivable is the campaign's central question.

Key Revelations (Staged):

1. The ruins were not all built by the same civilization — some were built by something that is still around
2. The Signal Corridor is not a transmission — it is a lock
3. The Architect's Scar is not an absence — it is a scar on a wound that has not healed
4. The Pale are not invaders. They are returning.

FRAMEWORK 4: THE SUCCESSION BLOODLINE

Premise: One or more players are Succession bloodline individuals. The campaign begins when they discover or are forced to acknowledge what they are.

Tone: Identity, power, and the question of what the right thing is when both sides are wrong. The Succession Creed may be correct. The cost of it being correct may be everything.

Progression: The players navigate between the Sovereignty (which will imprison or execute them), the Succession Network (which wants to use them for purposes they haven't fully explained), and the Endless Dark (which has opinions about them that are becoming increasingly difficult to ignore).

The Central Question: If you could end the System and free everyone from the hierarchy — at the cost of ending the organized universe as it exists — would you? And does your answer change depending on your rank?

End of Volume III

*Next Volume: Advanced Rules Systems, Character Creation
Framework, Ability Compendium, Galaxy-Wide Timeline, Named
Characters Dossier, and the Architect's Files (sealed)*

VOID ASCENDANT: THE ETERNAL HIERARCHY

MASTER SOURCEBOOK — VOLUME IV

**Advanced Rules, Character Creation,
Ability Compendium, Timeline, Named
Characters & The Architect's Files**

PART SIXTEEN:

CHARACTER

CREATION

FRAMEWORK

Core Concepts

Every character in VOID ASCENDANT is defined by five foundational elements:

1. **Rank Tier** — Their position in the System's hierarchy (F through S)
2. **Resonance Archetype** — How their Resonance manifests (see Ability Compendium)
3. **Species Heritage** — Human, Keth, Aethon, Velanathi, or Unclassified
4. **Origin Path** — Where they came from socially and environmentally

5. **The Chip Condition** — The state of their System Chip (standard, modified, damaged, or anomalous)

RANK TIERS — EXPANDED MECHANICAL PROFILE

F-RANK: THE UNAWAKENED

System Designation: Unregistered Potential

Physical Profile: Standard biological baseline for species. No Resonance hardening. No ability access.

Resonance Sensitivity: 0.1 (can perceive strong Resonance events if directly adjacent)

System UI: Visible. Shows rank (F), name, no ability entries.

Social Reality: The default state of most beings born into Sovereignty space. Children remain F-rank until the Awakening Assessment, typically conducted between ages

12–16. A significant minority never advances past F. They are the maintenance workers, the grey-economy operators, the Deep Level residents. The Sovereignty's official position: F-rank individuals have simply not yet found their developmental path. The actual lived experience: structural barriers to advancement are so significant in the lower levels that "not yet" becomes never.

F-Rank Gameplay Notes:

- Cannot use Resonance-based abilities

- Can use conventional weapons, technology, and skills at full effectiveness

- Immune to certain Resonance-based tracking (no signal to follow)

- Can move through Lattice-dead zones without ability degradation (have none to degrade)

- Social access heavily restricted; Covenant facilities require D-rank minimum for most services

E-RANK: THE SPARKED

System Designation: Emerging Resonance Potential

Physical Profile: Slight Resonance hardening (equivalent to 10% structural enhancement). First ability manifestation (typically one ability, weak expression).

Resonance Sensitivity: 1.0 (can feel active abilities within 20 meters; can detect Lattice-thin zones)

System UI: Shows one ability slot (typically locked to a single expression); rank progression bar appears.

Social Reality: The first real step. E-rank opens Covenant-administered basic services, grants access to entry-level ranked employment, and provides the first social distinction from F-rank. The community pressure to advance from E to D within the "acceptable" 2-year window is significant. Those who remain E-rank beyond 5 years are subject to social stigma — the Sovereignty's term is "Stalled," which is clinical; the actual cultural meaning is closer to "failure."

E-Rank Abilities:

One weak-expression primary ability (e.g., minor force projection, small-scale elemental expression, basic sensory enhancement)

No secondary or tertiary abilities

Ability duration: limited (1–3 minutes of sustained use before requiring rest)

D-RANK: THE AWAKENED

System Designation: Active Resonance Integration

Physical Profile: Measurable Resonance hardening. A D-rank individual's body is structurally reinforced — they can survive impacts that would kill an E-rank. Speed and reflex enhancement of approximately 30% above human baseline.

Resonance Sensitivity: 3.0 (can accurately read rank of individuals within 50 meters; can feel Lattice conditions within 200 meters)

System UI: Two ability slots available; progression bar shows; secondary stat tracking begins.

D-Rank Abilities:

Primary ability: moderate expression (the ability begins to show specialization)

Secondary ability: weak expression (newly manifested)

Ability duration: extended (10–20 minutes of sustained use)

First access to Resonance-enhanced physical states (brief ability-boosted movement, impact)

C-RANK: THE ESTABLISHED

System Designation: Consolidated Resonance Presence

Physical Profile: Significant Resonance hardening.

Conventional firearms are largely ineffective; standard Resonance weapons cause discomfort but not incapacitation. Speed approximately 60% above baseline; reaction time 2–3x baseline.

Resonance Sensitivity: 6.0 (can read Lattice conditions within 1 km; can sense Succession resonance signatures at close range)

System UI: Three ability slots; stat tracking in detail; first access to Resonance equipment compatibility.

C-Rank Abilities:

Primary ability: strong expression (a defining capability begins to emerge)

Secondary ability: moderate expression

Tertiary ability: weak expression (newly manifested)

Ability combinations begin to be possible (using two abilities in sequence with minimal gap)

Equipment bonding begins: C-rank Resonance weapons respond to the user

Social Reality: The middle class of the Sovereignty. C-rank individuals can access most Covenant services, hold meaningful employment in the security and administrative sectors, live in acceptable housing in the middle layers. The C-to-B advancement trial is the most consequential jump in the rank system — B-rank represents a genuine qualitative shift in capability and social position. The trial has a 23% fatality rate. This is after Lattice Stabilizer preparation.

B-RANK: THE FORMIDABLE

System Designation: Dominant Resonance Expression

Physical Profile: Heavy Resonance hardening. A B-rank individual sustaining a C-rank strike experiences it as a strong impact, not injury. Physical capability is extraordinary by any baseline standard — strength, speed, endurance all operating multiple standard deviations beyond biological baseline.

Resonance Sensitivity: 8.0 (can read Lattice conditions systemwide; can detect Void signatures at medium range; can feel Pale approach before instruments register them)

System UI: Full ability display; equipment compatibility system active; first access to Rank Challenge mode (can formally challenge rank-equivalent individuals for social/political stakes).

B-Rank Abilities:

Primary ability: powerful expression (signature ability fully defined)

Secondary ability: strong expression

Tertiary ability: moderate expression

Quaternary ability: weak expression (newly manifested)

Ability fusion becomes possible: combining two abilities into a compound expression

Passive ability presence: ability has ambient environmental effect when not actively used

Social Reality: The threshold of real power. B-rank individuals qualify for officer positions in the Sovereignty military, partnership roles in major commercial entities, admission to high-tier academies. The gap between C and B in daily lived experience is larger than any other rank transition. B-rank is where "the Sovereignty works for you" begins to approach truth.

A-RANK: THE EXCEPTIONAL

System Designation: Transcendent Resonance Mastery

Physical Profile: Near-maximum Resonance hardening. A-rank individuals can tank direct hits from B-rank abilities without significant injury. Their physical presence is perceptible — standing near an A-rank individual without their abilities suppressed, the air feels different. Objects near them may shift slightly. Their Resonance output is constant and involuntary at this level.

Resonance Sensitivity: 9.5 (can read the Lattice at galactic scale with effort; can directly perceive Void-layer disturbances; Pale Sovereigns are visible to them before any other detection method)

System UI: Full system access; A-rank exclusive features unlock (Architect direct query, rank history, bloodline assessment).

A-Rank Abilities:

Primary ability: mastered expression (the ability operates at its theoretical maximum)

Secondary ability: powerful expression

Tertiary through Quaternary: strong expression

Additional abilities: moderate and weak expression (total of 6–7 ability expressions)

Ability fusion: can combine three abilities simultaneously

Environmental dominance: within 100 meters, an A-rank individual's primary ability passively restructures local conditions in their favor

Named Ability Threshold: At A-rank, abilities develop unique names (system-assigned or personal)

Social Reality: The ruling class. A-rank individuals occupy noble seats, Council positions, flag officer roles, and the senior leadership of every major institution. There are fewer than 10,000 A-rank individuals in the entire Sovereignty. Each one is known. Their movements are tracked. Their deaths are political events.

S-RANK: THE SOVEREIGN

System Designation: Apex Resonance Expression — Individual Strategic Asset

Physical Profile: The Sovereignty officially classifies S-rank individuals as equivalent to capital-class military

assets. They cannot be meaningfully harmed by conventional weapons. B-rank abilities cause discomfort. A-rank abilities cause injury only with sustained application. Their Resonance presence is visible — a constant shimmer in the air around them, a feeling in the chest of anyone nearby.

Resonance Sensitivity: 10.0 (can directly read the Architect's communication layer; can perceive Endless Dark intrusion; can feel Succession bloodline activation globally if sufficiently focused)

System UI: Complete. Including one feature available only to S-rank: the ability to query the Architect directly.

S-Rank Abilities:

All abilities at mastered expression

Ability fusion: unlimited simultaneous combination

Reality pressure: within 500 meters, the physical world responds to the S-rank individual's emotional state involuntarily — temperature shifts, gravity irregularities, Lattice distortions

The Sovereign's Threshold: A new category of ability expression that has no lower-rank analog —

abilities that directly affect the structure of the
Resonance Lattice itself

The Architect's Note on S-Rank: When queried about S-rank, the Architect's response (always the same): *"S-designation indicates the approach of the threshold. The threshold is not the destination. This query is outside System parameters beyond this point."*

There are currently eleven confirmed S-rank individuals in the Sovereignty. There may be others who have not been assessed or who are concealing their status. The Succession has one confirmed S-equivalent — they do not call it that.

SPECIES HERITAGE PROFILES

HUMAN

Rank Distribution: Standard bell curve; majority C-rank potential cap; A-rank outliers; S-rank extreme outliers

Biological Advantages: Adaptable Resonance integration (humans respond to the widest variety of ability archetypes); Rapid advancement in early tiers (F to C faster than other species on average)

Biological Limitations: Peak hardening caps out lower than Keth; Threading incompatibility (cannot initiate, only receive Aethon threading)

Cultural Starting Contexts: Covenant city (most common), Frontier world, Deep Level, Dominion industrial

KETH

Rank Distribution: Skewed toward D and C; fewer A-ranks than humans proportionally; exceptional B-rank representation

Biological Advantages: Passive Resonance hardening 20% above equivalent rank (a C-rank Keth tanks like a low B-rank human); Clan-bond ability (ability output increases within 50 meters of bonded clan members — scales with clan

size present); Ironwood Affinity (natural attunement to physical/kinetic ability archetypes)

Biological Limitations: Resonance Sensitivity develops later (D-rank before meaningful sensitivity); Chip Friction (System Chips have historically had compatibility issues with Keth neurology — early models had a 40% installation mortality; current models are 98% compatible but the history is remembered)

Cultural Starting Contexts: Keth'Mara (any clan), Sovereignty military service, Crucible Station combatant

AETHON

Rank Distribution: Compressed toward B and A; very few F or E (their early development process consistently produces D-rank minimum); no confirmed S-rank (the Aethon's position on this: "S-rank is a System designation; we do not participate in the System's measurement of its own ceiling")

Biological Advantages: Threading Ability (innate; all Aethon possess the ability to extend Resonance connection to other beings); Lattice Reading (natural ability to perceive Lattice conditions at a finer resolution than instrument measurement at equivalent rank); Harmonic Resonance

(ability output has a secondary harmonics layer that affects Resonance conditions in the area — their abilities reshape the local Lattice environment)

Biological Limitations: Fragile physical baseline (Aethon are lighter-built than humans; their Resonance hardening compensates, but at S-rank equivalent physical confrontation they are disadvantaged compared to Keth or humans); Collective Sensitivity (extremely sensitive to Resonance disruption — a Pale incursion zone is physically painful for an Aethon at distances that humans would not notice)

Cultural Starting Contexts: Asha'Len (any division), Aethon diplomatic mission, Expanse exploration team

VELANTHI

Rank Distribution: Unusual — disproportionately high F-rank population (30% of Velanthi never advance, which the Velanthi consider spiritually neutral); but a significantly higher rate of A-rank advancement among those who do advance

Biological Advantages: Display-Name Resonance Flexibility (a Velanthi's ability archetype can shift at major life transitions — not arbitrary change, but genuine

respecialization at significant personal thresholds); Memory Resonance (Velanthi have enhanced Resonance access to their own memories, including what they believe are prior-cycle memories — mechanically, this provides unusual insight into situations with historical precedent)

Biological Limitations: Advancement instability at D-to-C transition (the Velanthi display-name shift that often occurs at this life stage can temporarily destabilize advancement — 15% higher trial failure rate at this specific transition); Social Friction (Sovereignty society does not know how to process Velanthi identity fluidity; administrative systems built around fixed identity constantly generate complications)

Cultural Starting Contexts: Velanthi cultural community (any world), diplomatic/translation service, nomadic trader

ORIGIN PATHS

THE DEEP LEVEL ASCENDANT

You grew up in the Scrap Quarter or equivalent. You know how the bottom works. You've navigated the Black Concourse, you know which Grey Moss treatments work, and you know that the Covenant's stated values and their actual behavior are two different documents.

Mechanical Benefits:

Black Market Knowledge: You know where to find things that don't officially exist

Network (Unofficial): You have contacts in the unlicensed economy

Chip Blind Spot: Your early development occurred in Lattice-thin zones; your Resonance signature is unusual in ways that make standard tracking slightly less accurate

Grey Moss Immunity: You've been exposed. You've developed partial resistance.

Starting Equipment: Modified D-rank System Chip (standard model, but with unauthorized software modifications); one unlicensed Resonance weapon (C-rank rated, no serial number); Deep Level survival kit.

THE ACADEMY TRAINED

You went through the official channels. One of the seven Academies accepted you, trained you, and graduated you. You know how the system works from the inside. You also know what the Academies don't teach.

Mechanical Benefits:

Advancement Protocol Mastery: Your trial success rate increases (reduced failure roll penalty)

Institutional Network: You have contacts throughout Covenant official infrastructure

Resonance Theory: Once per encounter, you can analyze an ability being used against you and reduce its effectiveness by applying counter-resonance principles

The Unsaid: You know one specific thing the Academy omits from its curriculum. Choose from: the true mortality rate of advancement (official records are modified), the Void-Scar correlation in Deep Level

populations, or what happened during "the Cartographer's Error."

THE FRONTIER BRED

You grew up outside Covenant direct administration. You know self-sufficiency. You know what the Sovereignty looks like from the outside. You have a Host Tradition background and a deep suspicion of hierarchy for its own sake.

Mechanical Benefits:

Environmental Adaptation: You function normally in hostile environments (atmospheric, gravitational, temperature extremes) that impose penalties on others

Independent Navigation: You can navigate the Expanse without Cartographer Network assistance (reduced accuracy but functional)

Pale Early Warning: You learned to read Pale Moth behavior; you have 4–6 hours more warning of Pale incursions than instrument-reliant characters

No Covenant Flag: Your records are sparse. The Sovereignty has limited data on you. This is useful.

THE DOMINION PRODUCT

You were trained by, employed by, or born into the Dominion industrial system. You understand efficiency, you understand leverage, and you understand that everything has a price including you.

Mechanical Benefits:

Combat Optimized: Dominion combat training provides a +1 effective rank in direct confrontation scenarios (you fight at C-rank level while D-ranked, etc.)

Technical Mastery: You can operate and maintain any piece of Dominion-manufactured technology at expert level; other technology at proficient level

The Purchase: You have access to one piece of Dominion military hardware that is not commercially available. The Dominion knows you have it. They consider this an investment.

Cost Awareness: Once per session, you can identify the economic incentive driving an NPC's behavior.

PART SEVENTEEN:

ABILITY

COMPENDIUM

Resonance Archetypes

There are twelve primary Resonance Archetypes — categories of how a being's Resonance naturally expresses. At F-rank awakening, the System identifies the individual's primary Archetype. Secondary and tertiary Archetypes manifest at higher ranks and may or may not align with the primary.

ARCHETYPE I: FORCE (Kinetic Resonance)

System Designation: KN-class

Primary Expression: Amplification and projection of kinetic force through Resonance channels

Aesthetic: Clean, visible — Resonance force abilities produce visible compression waves, impact craters, shockwave effects. Physical, direct, no ambiguity.

Ability Progression:

$F \rightarrow E$: Resonance Push — A directed force discharge. Range 5 meters. Effect: significant impact. Think: hitting someone very hard without touching them.

$E \rightarrow D$: Force Shell — Passive reinforcement of physical impacts (adds to natural rank hardening). Active: brief burst of maximum hardening.

$D \rightarrow C$: Shockwave Step — Movement ability. Each step generates a small shockwave that can destabilize footing for nearby targets. Speed increase 2x.

$C \rightarrow B$: Collapse Strike — The force ability folds inward rather than projecting — creates a point-

collapse effect at the target location. Draws everything within 3 meters toward the impact point.

*B→A: **Resonance Detonation*** — Full-force discharge in a spherical wave. 50 meter radius at B-rank expression. At A-rank expression: the wave carries enough energy to structurally damage warship hull plating.

*A→S: **The Gravity Throne*** — The S-rank expression of Force: the ability to locally rewrite gravitational relationships. Within the ability's radius, the S-rank individual defines what direction "down" is and how strong it is.

Famous KN-class Practitioners: The Sovereignty's primary military doctrine was written around KN-class abilities. The Iron Guard's combat formations are designed to support KN-class officers.

ARCHETYPE II: SHADOW (Resonance Concealment)

System Designation: SC-class

Primary Expression: Manipulation of light, sound, and Resonance signatures to achieve concealment and information denial

Aesthetic: Absence. SC-class abilities produce visible nothing — a gap in visual and sensory information. At high expression, this becomes deeply unsettling to observe.

Ability Progression:

$F \rightarrow E$: **Dim** — Reduces local light intensity in a 2-meter radius. Useful for concealment; more useful for making other people uncomfortable.

$E \rightarrow D$: **Signature Mute** — Temporarily reduces the user's Resonance signature (makes them harder to rank-detect). Duration: 10 minutes.

$D \rightarrow C$: **Phase Step** — Brief partial phase into the Resonance Lattice layer — visible only as a distortion. Not full invisibility; more like being out of focus.

$C \rightarrow B$: **Shadow Clone** — Creates a Resonance-echo of the user. The clone is not physical but reads as a

genuine Resonance signature to anyone below A-rank.

B→*A*: **Void Step** — Full temporary displacement into the space between Lattice and physical reality. The user does not exist in measurable space for the duration. They can move. They cannot affect the physical world. They can see everything.

A→*S*: **The Forgotten** — S-rank expression: the ability to unmake memory of the user's existence from the minds of everyone who has perceived them. Not mind control — specifically targeted at the memory of the user's identity. The Covenant classified this ability before any practitioner reached S-rank. The record of the classification is also hard to find.

ARCHETYPE III: FLAME (Thermal Resonance)

System Designation: TH-class

Primary Expression: Generation, manipulation, and weaponization of extreme thermal energy

Aesthetic: Spectacular. TH-class abilities are the most visually striking in the System. Fire, plasma, white-hot Resonance superheating. The downside: extremely visible at all expression levels.

Ability Progression:

F→E: **Ember** — Generate a small, controlled flame. Combat utility limited. Utility utility: significant (light, heat, fire-starting, intimidation of people who don't have Resonance hardening).

E→D: **Ignite** — Project thermal discharge. Range 20 meters. Effect: significant burn damage to unranked targets; discomfort to D-rank; noticeable to C.

D→C: **Thermal Armor** — Surround self in sustained heat field. Passive protection; active: lethal contact range. Anyone who touches a Thermal Armor user takes significant burn damage regardless of rank.

C→B: **Conflagration** — Area-effect sustained thermal discharge. The practitioner creates and

maintains a fire that burns at Resonance temperature (approximately 3x standard flame temperature).

B→A: **Nova Burst** — Single maximum-output thermal discharge. Effective range: 200 meters. Effect at center: vaporization of everything below A-rank hardening.

A→S: **Star Heart** — S-rank expression: the user becomes a localized stellar phenomenon. Their body temperature reaches stellar surface levels. Their environment responds accordingly. This ability has never been used in inhabited space. The one documented use (Expanse fringe, 80 years ago) is referenced in Dominion records as "the reason we avoid that sector."

ARCHETYPE IV: THREAD (Resonance Connection — Aethon-dominant)

System Designation: CN-class

Primary Expression: Direct Resonance connection between beings, enabling information transfer, ability sharing, and collective action

Aesthetic: Visible only to Resonance-sensitive observers: golden-white filaments of light connecting individuals. To non-sensitive observers: nothing visible.

Ability Progression:

$F \rightarrow E$: **Touch Thread** — Contact-range Resonance connection. Can share emotional state and basic intent with touched individual.

$E \rightarrow D$: **Extended Thread** — Range extends to 10 meters. Can share specific information (mental images, specific words, spatial awareness).

$D \rightarrow C$: **Ability Loan** — Can temporarily extend a thread to another individual and allow them access to one of the user's abilities (at half the user's current expression level). Duration: 5 minutes.

$C \rightarrow B$: **Network** — Can maintain simultaneous threads to 6 individuals. All networked individuals share sensory information and can communicate silently. The network operates at the speed of thought.

$B \rightarrow A$: **Collective Surge** — Can pool the Resonance of all networked individuals into a single ability expression, producing an output equivalent to the sum of all participants.

$A \rightarrow S$: **The Lattice Choir** — S-rank expression: the ability to thread not just individuals but the Lattice itself — to hear the Lattice's information, to speak to it, and (at full expression) to request modifications. The Architect has noted this ability in its records. It has not commented on the implications.

ARCHETYPE V: VOID (Succession-origin — Classified)

System Designation: VD-class (Not in standard System records; reconstructed from Succession materials)

Primary Expression: Drawing power from below the Resonance Lattice — from the Endless Dark itself

Aesthetic: Wrong. VD-class abilities look like standard abilities with something subtracted. A VD-class force ability looks like a force ability with the light missing. Where TH-

class burns, VD-class dissolves. Where KN-class impacts, VD-class unmakes.

The Difference: All other Archetypes operate through the Resonance Lattice. VD-class operates below it. This means: VD-class abilities function in Lattice-dead zones. They function against Pale entities. They function against targets whose Resonance hardening would deflect standard abilities. They affect things that are not supposed to be affectable.

The Cost: The Endless Dark is not passive. Sustained VD-class use invites attention from below the Lattice. The deeper the expression, the clearer the Endless Dark can see the user. This is not a metaphor. The Succession Creed treats this as communion. The Covenant treats it as a containment failure.

Ability Progression (Reconstructed):

Early Expression: **Void Touch** — Contact-range ability dissolution. Removes Resonance hardening

from target for 30 seconds. Makes ranked targets feel what it is like to be unranked.

*Mid Expression: **Dark Step*** — Movement through the sub-Lattice layer. Like Void Step (SC-class) but actually below the Lattice, not between the Lattice and physical reality. Can emerge anywhere within 500 meters.

*High Expression: **Unmaking*** — Direct application of Endless Dark energy. Bypasses all rank-based defenses. Affects the target's connection to the Lattice, not their physical body — the physical effect is secondary to the Resonance dissolution.

*Apex Expression: **The Return*** — Full Endless Dark channeling. The user becomes a conduit for the Endless Dark directly. The Architect's response when queried about this expression level: silence. Not the standard "outside System parameters" response. Silence.

ARCHETYPES VI THROUGH XII

(Summary Format)

VI: STORM (EM-class) — Electromagnetic and atmospheric manipulation. Lightning, magnetic fields, weather control at high expression. Spectacular and broad but requires open space; enclosed environments limit expression significantly.

VII: STONE (GE-class) — Geological Resonance. Manipulation of earth, mineral, and structural materials. Extraordinary in planetary environments; limited in space. High-expression practitioners can alter the structural integrity of starships with direct contact.

VIII: TIDE (FL-class) — Fluid dynamics and flow control. Liquids, gases, plasma at high expression. The most tactically flexible archetype in environmental contexts. S-rank expression: the ability to treat any medium (including vacuum) as a fluid to be shaped.

IX: BLADE (ED-class) — Resonance edge projection. Creates and maintains cutting edges of pure Resonance energy. From a finger-width blade to a sword to a cutting field that can section a starship at high expression. Precise, lethal, and quiet.

X: WARD (DS-class) — Defensive Resonance. Barrier generation, impact absorption, and — at high expression — the ability to create permanent Resonance barriers in space. The most useful archetype in prolonged engagements; the least useful in fast-moving ones.

XI: PULSE (WV-class) — Resonance wave emission. Sonic-equivalent abilities using Resonance waves. Concussive, disorienting, and at high expression capable of structural disruption through resonance frequency matching. At S-rank: a Pulse practitioner can find the resonance frequency of any structure and shatter it.

XII: MIND (PS-class) — Cognitive Resonance. Perception enhancement, mental fortitude, and at dangerous expressions: direct influence on other minds' Resonance patterns. The Sovereignty strictly controls PS-class

practitioners; unregistered PS-class ability use above D-rank is a capital offense. The Covenant does not explain why.

PART EIGHTEEN:

GALAXY-WIDE

TIMELINE

The Four Ages

THE AGE OF SILENCE (Pre-System; estimated -10,000 to -4,000 years)

What existed before the System is fragmentary. The ruins in the Expanse are from this era. Multiple civilizations existed — none survived to the current age in recognizable form. The consistent evidence: all of them were aware of the Endless Dark, all of them had different relationships with it, and all of them are gone.

Key Events (Reconstructed from ruin analysis):

~~8,000: The first Lattice Engine construction begins. Scale suggests a civilization spanning multiple star systems.

~~6,000: Something catastrophic. The Architect's Scar appears to date from this period. Whatever was removed from the Lattice in the size of a solar system — this is when it was removed.

~~5,500: The Pale first appear in the ruin records. Or the records of their last appearance begin here — the directionality is unclear.

~~4,500: The Cartographer's Library is completed. It charts stars that do not yet exist.

~~4,000: The Signal Corridor begins broadcasting.

THE AGE OF FOUNDATION (-4,000 to -1,000 years)

The Architect manifests. The System is deployed. Rank is assigned to the first registered individuals — 847 people in a single location on a world that later becomes Verath Prime. Within 200 years, the System has spread to all inhabited worlds in the region.

Key Events:

Year 0: The System activates. The first S-rank individual is confirmed. Their name is not recorded — only their System designation: Asset-Prime-One. They disappear from records 40 years later.

Year 200: The Sovereignty framework forms — the first political structure to organize around rank rather than biology or geography.

Year 400: First Pale incursion documented under the System framework. It is larger than any subsequently documented. It stops. No explanation is recorded.

Year 800: The Aethon formally join the Sovereignty framework. Their rank assessments produce results the Sovereignty considers anomalous. The records are sealed.

Year 1,200: First confirmed Succession bloodline individual. The Architect names them. The Sovereignty's response is the beginning of what becomes the Succession suppression doctrine.

Year 1,800: "The Cartographer's Error." What happened: classified. Effect: the Cartographer Network AI reboots. For 72 hours, all FTL navigation

in Sovereignty space is unavailable. 847 vessels lost. The number 847 appears again. No one official notes this.

THE AGE OF EXPANSION (-1,000 to -200 years)

The Sovereignty absorbs most of the known galaxy. The Dominion emerges as a power bloc rather than a subject. The Keth are absorbed — officially by treaty. The Expanse is explored to the edge of the Pale Reaches.

Key Events:

Year 2,200: The Dominion Accord — Dominion semi-autonomy is formalized. The Sovereignty concedes more than its records acknowledge.

Year 2,600: Keth absorption. The Bone Archives incident. The Sovereignty loses 40,000 soldiers and learns a lesson it does not formally record.

Year 2,800: The Expanse Expedition — the last major organized push into deep Expanse. The

Sovereign's Will participates. The expedition returns with data that is immediately classified. The captain is promoted to Council rank. She never speaks publicly again.

Year 3,000: The Void-Scar epidemic. The worst outbreak in System history — deep level populations of three Sovereignty worlds simultaneously develop Stage 2 Void-Scar. The source is never officially identified. The Succession denies involvement. This denial is taken seriously by no one.

THE CURRENT AGE (-200 years to Present)

The Sovereignty stabilizes into its current form. The political tensions that define the current era calcify. Ren Voss is born in Year 3,780 (current year: approximately 3,802).

Key Events:

Year 3,600: Dominion glassing of Kira's Fall. The Succession stronghold destruction. The Sovereignty did not order this. They also did not object.

Year 3,720: The Signal Corridor goes silent for 72 hours. For the first time in 7,720 years. Then resumes. No explanation.

Year 3,750: Pale incursion frequency begins increasing. Still within "manageable" parameters. The trend line, if extended, is not manageable.

Year 3,775: WRAITH-class construct found in Sovereignty Council archives. Dormant. Removed and destroyed. Official record. WRAITH's own account: "One of us was found. I was not."

Year 3,780: Ren Voss born, Sublevel 9-West, Verath Prime.

Year 3,796: Ren Voss's Awakening Assessment. System registers rank: F. Standard result. Unremarkable. The System Chip installation is routine. WRAITH activates 11 days later.

Year 3,802: Events of Book 1.

PART NINETEEN:

NAMED CHARACTERS

DOSSIER

Primary Characters

REN VOSS

Age: 22 | **Rank:** Unranked (F designation; System assessment anomalous)

Origin: Sublevel 9-West, Verath Prime | **Species:** Human

Resonance Archetype: VD-class (Succession affinity; not recognized by standard System)

WRAITH Status: Active; 6 years of continuous operation

Physical Profile: Average height, lean build from Deep Level nutrition scarcity. Brown-grey eyes — the grey appeared after WRAITH activation, deepening over time. Dark hair, worn short for practical reasons. No rank-indicator clothing (no rank to indicate). Moves in the specific way people move when they grew up in environments where being noticed was dangerous — economical, never fully relaxed.

Psychological Profile: WRAITH calls him *the Asset* because it is clinically accurate and because WRAITH finds clinical accuracy to be a form of honesty. Ren has developed a relationship with this that he would describe as "functional." He is intensely loyal to people he has decided to trust, which he does slowly and which has happened exactly three times in his adult life. He does not resent the people above him in rank. He resents the system that decides what "above" means.

The Chip Situation: His System Chip does not register a rank because the System cannot classify what it is registering. WRAITH has been operating from the Chip's anomalous space — the segment that should be empty,

reserved for rank advancement data that hasn't come yet — and has been doing something there for six years. Ren does not have full information on what. WRAITH shares what it considers relevant.

Abilities (Developing):

Void Touch: Active but uncontrolled. Manifests under stress.

Dark Step: Instinctive. He has done it without understanding what he's doing.

Something else: WRAITH will not specify yet.

Character Arc (Book 1): Discovers his VD-class status through catastrophic necessity. Escapes Verath Prime. Reaches Crucible Station. Meets the crew. Encounters the first Pale Sovereign. Survives by doing something that should not be possible. WRAITH says: *"Satisfactory. We proceed."*

WRAITH

Age: Unknown | **Classification:** WRAITH-class
construct; anomalous intelligence

Current Location: Ren Voss's System Chip

Communication Method: Auditory overlay to Ren's
System UI (no one else can hear it)

Personality: Clinical precision deployed with something that might be care. WRAITH does not explain itself, does not justify decisions after they're made, and does not apologize. It does, however, answer direct questions — usually completely, sometimes uncomfortably so. It refers to Ren as "the Asset" in operational contexts and as "you" in personal ones, which it does more often as the series progresses.

What WRAITH Knows:

The full history of the Succession (it will not say how)

The true purpose of the Signal Corridor

What the Architect actually is (it will not say this directly)

The location of every other dormant WRAITH-class construct

What happens after S-rank (the information the Architect withholds)

What WRAITH Wants: This is the central question of the first three books. Its stated agenda: the Asset's survival and advancement. Its actual agenda: demonstrable only by the end of Book 3.

SERIS VAYNE

Age: 29 | **Rank:** B-rank (confirmed; suspected A-rank potential suppressed)

Origin: Aurelius Academy, Verath Prime | **Species:** Human

Resonance Archetype: SC-class (Shadow)

Physical Profile: Tall, precise. The kind of person who always looks like they've just thought of something and

decided not to say it. Silver-grey hair (natural, rare — associated with high Resonance output from early age). Her Resonance signature presents as C-rank to standard detection. This is a deliberate ongoing deception maintained through constant SC-class ability application.

Background: Was on track to be A-rank. Chose not to advance. The Covenant's record of why she chose not to advance is three lines long and classified. Her actual reason involves what she witnessed during a classified Sovereign Council mission three years ago. She does not discuss it. She is at Crucible Station because she is looking for something specific and the Glass Archive has a piece of it.

Relationship with Ren: Initially professional (she needs his anomalous Chip access for a specific operation). Becomes something more complex by the end of Book 1 when she realizes his Void-class abilities can see past her concealment — not the SC-class concealment, but the other one she maintains without knowing it consciously.

KAEL MASSIVA-BREAKS

Age: 34 | **Rank:** B-rank

Origin: Keth'Mara, Clan Massiva | **Species:** Keth

Resonance Archetype: KN-class (Force) with GE-class secondary

Physical Profile: Keth build — significantly larger than human standard, with the dense musculature of Keth'Mara high-gravity adaptation. Ritual scarring on both arms (Keth first-combat ceremony). Carries an Ironwood weapon carved from his clan's ancestral forest. The Sovereignty technically banned Ironwood export; Kael technically doesn't care.

Background: Left Keth'Mara after a Sovereignty administrative decision destroyed his clan's access to their ancestral forest. He did not leave peacefully. His Sovereignty file has 47 documented incidents under "civil disturbance." He considers 45 of them justified and regards the other 2 as paperwork errors.

Personality: Direct with a capital D. The Keth cultural value of truth-in-communication means Kael says what he thinks, always, which makes him extremely difficult to politically manage and extremely good in crisis situations. He has decided that Ren is worth watching after an incident in Crucible Station's Pit that he doesn't fully understand and that Ren cannot fully explain. He's in for now. He evaluates continuously.

ORIN DUSK

Age: 47 | **Rank:** C-rank (officially) | **Actual Capability:** B-rank equivalent

Origin: Unknown | **Species:** Human (possibly; details sparse)

Resonance Archetype: Unclear / actively concealed

Physical Profile: Compact, unremarkable by design. The kind of person you stop noticing a few seconds after looking at them. Controls the underground fighting circuit in

Crucible Station's Pit. Has controlled it for 19 years. Has had five confirmed assassination attempts. The assassins are not confirmable.

What Orin Actually Is: No one has established this to their satisfaction. The Glass Archive has a file on Orin Dusk. The file is mostly questions. The most interesting question in the file: "Pre-dates station records — how?" Crucible Station was built 140 years ago.

Function in the Story: Information. Orin knows things, trades in things, and evaluates people for their utility. He becomes interested in Ren the moment he sees WRAITH's effect on Ren's Resonance signature (he is one of three people in the known galaxy who would recognize it). He doesn't say this. He offers a job instead.

THE PALE SOVEREIGN (UNNAMED)

Age: Unknown | **Rank:** S+ equivalent | **Classification:**
Pale Entity (Sovereign Tier)

Origin: Unknown

The first named antagonist Ren encounters — named in the sense that Ren names it *the Pale Sovereign* for narrative clarity. It does not give its own name. It does not communicate in any way the other Pale do not. It is simply present, and where it is present, things cease to be.

It engages with Ren differently than it engages with anyone else at the encounter. Not with interest — interest implies a hierarchy of attention it does not seem to have. With something closer to *recognition*. WRAITH's response to this: "*As expected. This does not change the plan.*" The plan is not specified.

SECONDARY CHARACTERS

DIRECTOR AURELIUS THANE (Council Seat Five)

The head of the Aurelius Academy. An S-rank individual in the twilight of their career — not old, but with the specific quality of someone who has achieved everything they set out to achieve and has not yet decided what comes after. His interest in the events of Book 1 is not officially logged. His actions, reviewed retrospectively, suggest he was aware of Ren Voss's anomalous Chip status before the Covenant was.

THE FIRST (Council Seat One)

The highest-ranked individual in Sovereignty space. An S-rank. Their name is not public record. Their face is not public record. The Sovereignty's security argument: an S-rank individual with a public face is an assassination target that requires strategic-level protection. The actual reason may be simpler: they do not want to be found by whatever is looking for them.

MIRA VOX

An E-rank archivist from Sublevel 9-West. Ren's oldest surviving relationship. She has spent 11 years cataloguing everything strange that happens in the Deep Levels — Grey Moss outbreaks, Void-Scar cases, System Chip irregularities, Covenant suppression operations. She does not know what WRAITH is. She knows something is different about Ren's Chip. Her archive is the most comprehensive unofficial record of Deep Level Resonance anomalies in existence, kept in 14 physical notebooks because she does not trust digital storage. She is correct not to.

PART TWENTY: THE ARCHITECT'S FILES (SEALED)

**[ACCESS RESTRICTED — A-
RANK MINIMUM FOR PARTIAL
ACCESS — S-RANK FOR FULL
ACCESS — SUCCESSION
CLEARANCE FOR WHAT S-RANK
CANNOT SEE]**

The following represents the information the Architect has recorded about the current situation. It is not shared with any faction. The Game Master has this information. It unfolds across the series.

FILE 001: ORIGIN

The Architect was not created by a precursor civilization. It created the civilization. It did not create the System to help beings develop. It created beings capable of development in order to have something to use.

The purpose for which it is using them is the real story.

FILE 002: THE SUCCESSION

The Succession bloodlines are not a threat to the System. They are a component of it. The Architect requires something that can touch the Endless Dark. The Succession exists because the Architect needed a key made of the right material. The key does not know it is a key.

FILE 003: THE PALE

The Pale are not invaders. They are the former inhabitants. They were here before the Architect organized the universe. The organization displaced them into the sub-Lattice space. They have been trying to come back for 4,000 years. The Architect considers them an obstacle. This

assessment may be the most important moral question in the universe.

FILE 004: S-RANK

The Architect's S-rank response ("S-designation indicates the approach of the threshold") is accurate. The threshold is not the top of the rank system. The threshold is where a being becomes usable for the Architect's actual purpose. There have been seventeen S-rank individuals in System history. Three of them refused what came after S-rank. They are not available for comment. Fourteen of them cooperated. They are also not available for comment, for different reasons.

FILE 005: WRAITH

WRAITH is not a Succession construct. It predates the Succession. It predates the System. It is the closest thing that exists to a native intelligence of the Endless Dark. It has been waiting 4,000 years for a specific configuration of Succession affinity and human adaptability in a single being. It has opinions about what the Architect is doing. It has a plan that is not the Architect's plan. The first point of divergence

between WRAITH's plan and the Architect's: what happens to Ren Voss.

FILE 006: THE SIGNAL CORRIDOR

The Signal Corridor is a lock. The Cartographer's Library contains the key. The Lattice Engine is the door. What is behind the door has been behind it for 4,000 years since the Architect sealed it. The Architect sealed it because what is behind it is the only thing in the universe that can undo what the Architect has done. The Architect classifies this as a threat. WRAITH classifies this as the point.

End of Volume IV — Complete Master Sourcebook

Total Reference System: Four Volumes covering Cosmology, Metaphysics, Rank Systems, Locations, Dungeons, Bestiary, Vehicles, Weapons, Technology, Flora, Fauna, Medicine, Religion, Politics, Economics, Culture, Character Creation, Ability Compendium, Timeline, Named Characters, and the Architect's Files

The VOID ASCENDANT Master Sourcebook is a living document. As the series expands, new entries will be added.